A PERSONAL COOKING NOTEBOOK

Fogo Baixo

Techniques and recipes tested at home — each one as running text and as a cooking table.

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Kneading is just a sped-up way of aligning gluten. Hydrated, resting dough does the same work alone, only slower — folds spaced out over time replace the stand mixer. The chapter opens with a single loaf, but the logic holds for any enriched dough.

26 No-knead sandwich bread

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Two sandwiches, two different water problems. One is made on the spot and eaten within fifteen minutes — the barrier is bread toasted on the griddle. The other spends a whole night in the fridge before a morning in a cool box — the barrier is cream cheese spread to the edge. In both, the same question decides what goes in: will this release water, and will the bread hold until it's eaten?

27 Caprese ciabatta with arugula

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BABY FOOD: STARTING SOLIDS

Five purées from the "Papai Papinha" series, recovered from handwritten notes between June and August 2023 — there were more than sixteen in all. All pressure-cooked, all saltless, all with texture matched to the baby's month. The lists are food families, not rules: swapping spinach for collards or ground beef for liver is the method working. Where the note gave no measurement, none was invented.

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30 Purée #5 — beans, arracacha and lime

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PART ONE

Techniques

The principles that recur in nearly every recipe. Read them once; after that they are just reference.

TECHNIQUE · WORKS FOR ANY BIRD WITH SKIN

The crisp-skin principle

Cold pan, low heat and patience produce glassy skin. Hurry produces rubber.

The fat has to render before the surface browns

Under the skin there is a layer of fat. If the surface browns before that fat melts, it stays trapped: the skin hardens on the outside and remains flabby underneath. Starting with a cold pan and raising the heat slowly gives the fat time to render and escape — the skin then fries in its own fat and turns to glass.

Water is the enemy

As long as there is moisture on the surface, the skin never gets past 100 °C, and nothing browns at 100 °C: all the heat goes into evaporating water instead of toasting. Patting dry with paper towel is not fussiness, it is the step that changes the result most. Chicken that has been marinating needs twice the care — the marinade leaves the skin soaked.

Full contact

Skin shrinks and buckles as it heats, and its middle stops touching the pan. A weight on top — another pan, a saucepan filled with water — keeps the whole surface against the metal. Without weight you get a browned rim around a pale centre.

Don't poke it

Every time you lift the piece, steam gets underneath and softens what was already crisp. Twelve to fifteen minutes without touching feels like a long time the first time. It is the right time.

Sugar burns first

Honey, soy sauce and barbecue sauce caramelise long before the skin is done. For this method, dry seasoning only: salt, herbs, pepper, paprika, garlic. Sweetness goes on later, at the table, if at all.

NOTES

- Doneness: 75 °C at the centre is what actually guarantees safety. The bone pulling free easily is a bonus sign, not a substitute for a thermometer.
- Seasoned raw chicken keeps 1 to 2 days in the fridge, held continuously at 4 °C or below. Smell and texture signal spoilage but do not confirm safety — when in doubt about time or temperature, discard it.
- A wet marinade works against you. If you use one, drain and dry thoroughly before it hits the heat.

TECHNIQUE · THE RULE THAT RUNS THROUGH THE WHOLE BOOK

Salt discipline

Almost every recipe here has three or four hidden sources of sodium. Taste first, always.

Salt almost never comes only from the salt cellar

Look at the pattern. Feijoada has dried salted beef, salted ribs, ear, tail, paio and calabresa sausage — six sources before any pinch. Fried rice has bacon, calabresa, soy sauce and MSG. The orzo has a stock cube, hondashi and lemon pepper. The flap steak marinade has soy sauce, Worcestershire, fish sauce and salt. The pork medallions have soy sauce in the sauce. The escabeche has both the fish and the vinegar bath already salted. In every one of these, salting at the start is betting blind.

The practical rule

Salt goes in at the end, after tasting — and often it does not go in at all. In recipes with a reduction (the medallion sauce, the reduced steak marinade), remember that concentrating the liquid concentrates the salt with it: a sauce that tastes right halfway through the reduction will be salty by the end.

The exceptions are few and clear

Meat that will be seared takes generous salt on the surface, only as it goes to the griddle — there the salt builds crust, not interior seasoning. Boiled potatoes take salt in the water, because that is the only chance to season them inside; afterwards, a light sprinkle. Salad takes salt only as it is served, or it turns to soup. Same for vinaigrette.

When the salt has already gone too far

With salted meats, the control is the soak: 24 hours in the fridge in plenty of water, changed every 3 to 4 hours. If you had less time, cook a small sample in water and taste it once fully cooked — never raw — to decide; if it is still salty, pre-boil for 15 minutes instead of 10 and change the water halfway.

NOTES

- Marinade that touched raw meat is not tasted or turned straight into a sauce: set a portion aside before adding the meat, or bring the used liquid to a full boil before reducing and tasting.
- If the sauce has soy sauce in it, ease off the salt everywhere else on the plate — meat and sides.
- Salting at the end can be corrected. Salting at the start cannot.

Doneness without a thermometer

Three habits solve doneness without a gadget: take it out of the fridge early, look inside, and let it rest.

The cold centre is the biggest enemy

Meat that goes from fridge straight to fire cooks outside-in with a huge gap between surface and middle — by the time the centre is right, the edge is overdone. Thin cut for the griddle: 20 to 30 minutes out of the fridge. Thick cut: 30 to 40 minutes. A whole flap steak for the oven: a full hour. This is not fussiness; it is what makes timing predictable.

Cut and peek

Without a thermometer, the method is to look. Make a small cut at the thickest point and read the colour: cold red in the middle means it needs more; warm pink is rare to medium-rare; barely pink, almost no pink and still moist is medium-well — which usually pleases most people in a piece served hot; even grey is well done, and there is no coming back. The cut loses a little juice, which matters not at all next to the cost of getting doneness wrong.

Dry browns, wet steams

The same principle as chicken skin applies to any seared meat. Paper towel on the surface before anything else — especially after marinating, which soaks it. A thin-bottomed pan plus wet meat is the combination that makes the piece release water and stew instead of browning.

Resting is not optional

Five minutes for a thin cut, eight to ten for a thick one or a whole flap steak. That is when the juices redistribute. Slicing sooner floods the board and dries out the meat — and with flap steak, slicing thin against the grain does more for tenderness than anything else in the recipe.

What does not reheat

Meat served medium does not go back on the heat: reheated medium flap steak turns to rubber. If you cannot serve immediately, change method — braised at 150–160 °C for 2.5 to 3 hours with liquid covering it reheats perfectly. Cold roast beef is the other valid path: roast to temperature, chill, slice thin and serve at room temperature. Never reheat.

NOTES

- Thermometer reference, if you have one: ~63 °C for pink pork, counting the rest; 75 °C for chicken.
- Black pepper burns on the griddle: add it after searing.
- Generous surface salt only as it goes to the heat.

TECHNIQUE · JUDGE BY WHAT YOU SEE, NOT BY THE DIAL

Griddle, pan and the 4.5 kW burner

Too much heat is the commonest mistake for anyone with a powerful burner. Pan choice and heat recovery matter more than raw power.

Heat recovery

What matters when cold meat hits the metal is not peak temperature but how much the surface holds without collapsing. A removable griddle over the big burner, cast iron and heavy-bottomed stainless hold heat and build good fond. Thin aluminium works, but drops temperature instantly: compensate by preheating well and searing in small batches, letting the pan recover between them.

Judge by what you see

On a 4.5 kW burner, 'medium' is far less flame than it looks. Watch the orzo bubbling, the meat sizzling, the colour of the garlic — not the dial position. The pan gets very hot and holds heat: give the command and wait for it to respond, instead of going to maximum and then chasing the damage.

Garlic burns in seconds

It appears in nearly every recipe here and it is the thing that most often ruins a base. Medium-low heat, and take it off sooner than seems necessary — the hot pan keeps cooking after you turn it off. Dark garlic makes the whole dish bitter.

Preheat and test

Griddle: 5 to 8 minutes on low-medium so the heat spreads. The flame concentrates in the centre, so sear in the centre. The test is a drop of water — it should skitter and vanish in 1 to 2 seconds. Vanishing instantly means it is not yet hot enough for the Leidenfrost effect. Sitting there boiling means it has a long way to go.

Non-stick makes no sauce

It barely builds fond, and the coating degrades over high heat. If the sauce comes from the bottom of the pan — and in this book it almost always does — use stainless or iron.

NOTES

- Fond stuck to the bottom is not a mistake, it is flavour. Deglaze with water, cachaça, beer or soy sauce and scrape.
- A wide, shallow pan evaporates and absorbs evenly; a deep, narrow one piles up and smothers.
- Alcohol in a very hot pan can ignite: take it off the heat before adding cachaça or wine.

TECHNIQUE · 3% SALT, EVERYTHING SUBMERGED, PH CONFIRMS

Brine fermenting without fear

Lacto-fermentation is simple and safe when three rules are followed. The fourth rule is knowing when to throw it out.

How it works

Vegetables submerged in brine ferment through lactic acid bacteria, which acidify the environment and protect against everything that spoils. Salt and acid do the preserving; time only deepens flavour, making it more sour and more rounded. That is why the timeline is flexible: a week gives a fresh result, a few months give a complex one, and neither is safer than the other.

Salt at 3% of total weight

Three per cent of the weight of vegetable plus water, not water alone. Weigh the whole thing in the jar and calculate from there. Ordinary salt works: iodine, at the levels found in table salt, does not bother the bacteria — at most it makes the brine slightly cloudy.

Everything submerged

It is above the liquid line that mould appears. A clean bag filled with 3% brine — not plain water, in case it leaks — pushed into the neck acts as a weight and seals off the air. Loose lid: fermentation releases CO_2 and a full jar overflows in the first days. Keep it on a small plate, away from sunlight. It will turn cloudy and bubble: that is correct.

Kahm or mould

A smooth white film on the surface is kahm, a harmless yeast — spoon it off and carry on. Anything fuzzy or hairy, of any colour, is mould: discard the whole batch, no scraping to save it. The smell must be sour and pleasant, like pickles; putrid means discard. A pH strip below 4 confirms it is safe.

NOTES

- Start tasting from day five to seven. The endpoint is taste, not the calendar.
- Blender only at the end. The mash version — fermented purée, salt calculated on the paste's weight, no water — is a different method: it ferments faster and dries out on top if neglected.
- Fermenting does not remove heat, it only rounds it. Calibrate the heat by tasting the raw blend: you can go up, not down.

TECHNIQUE · PRESSURE COOKER · NO SALT BEFORE AGE ONE

Baby food is food families, not recipes

Good baby food is not smooth baby food. One food family at a time, rising texture, and real seasoning from the start.

Good baby food is not smooth

The goal is real cooked flavour and rising texture: a baby needs to learn to chew, and a velvety purée delays that. Hence the pressure cooker — fast, even, little water, never turning to soup — and controlled mashing at the end, from fork-mashed to finely chopped.

Seven families, and who fills each slot rotates

What holds the whole series together is not an ingredient list, it is a list of families: a starchy root for energy and body (potato, arracacha, squash, yam); a coloured vegetable for vitamins, colour and sweetness (carrot, beetroot, peas, courgette); a leafy green for iron and flavour (spinach, collards, broccoli, watercress); a protein for iron and building (beef, chicken, fish, liver, beans, chickpeas, lentils); an aromatic for the taste of real cooking (onion, garlic, leek, celery); fat; and seasoning. Each batch picks one from each, and who fills each slot rotates with the market, the season and what is in the freezer. No family is compulsory in every batch, but no batch should have only two.

THE SEVEN FAMILIES

FAMILY	WHAT IT DOES	EXAMPLES
Starchy root	energy and body	potato, arracacha, squash, yam, cassava
Coloured vegetable	vitamins, colour, sweetness	carrot, beetroot, peas, courgette, chayote
Leafy green	iron, flavour, colour	spinach, collards, broccoli, watercress, escarole
Protein	iron and building	ground beef, pork, chicken, fish, liver, beans, chickpeas, lentils
Aromatic	the taste of real cooking	onion, garlic, leek, celery
Fat	calories and fat-soluble vitamins	neutral oil (sunflower)
Seasoning	training the palate	cumin, cinnamon, bay, herbs, lime zest

The base method, in seven steps

Pulses first, if any: soaked 8 to 12 hours with the water changed, pressure-cooked alone for 20 to 25 minutes until they crush between your fingers, then set aside with a little of their liquid. Then the sofrito: neutral oil, onion and leek until soft, garlic just until fragrant. Then the protein, seared and broken up until no pink remains. The hard vegetables in roughly 2 cm cubes, with water not quite covering — do not drown them, watery baby food becomes soup — and 4 to 6 minutes of pressure counted from the hiss. The greens go in last, with the lid already off, in the residual heat. Seasoning off the heat or in the final minutes. And texture at the very end, loosened with the cooking liquid, never with cold water.

No salt, no sugar, no honey

This is the one recipe in the notebook where salt discipline is absolute: no salt at all before age one. A baby's kidneys cannot handle the sodium, and taste calibrates early — food without salt in childhood means food with less salt for life. Honey is out too, because of the risk of infant botulism before age one. What goes in instead is onion, garlic, leek, cumin, cinnamon, bay, parsley and lime zest: seasoning is not salting. It is unseasoned baby food that tastes of nothing; unsalted and well seasoned, it is good.

Baby food needs fat

A baby has a small stomach and high calorie needs, and it is fat that carries vitamins A, D, E and K out of the vegetables and into the child. Lean baby food is bulky and thin on nutrition. Here it is neutral sunflower oil, not olive oil, for two reasons: it does not compete with the flavour of the food — at this stage the baby is learning the taste of the vegetable, not of the oil — and it survives the sofrito without turning bitter. It goes in twice: in the sofrito and as a drizzle on the plate.

Liver, once a week

It is the densest source of iron available at this stage, and it was part of the rotation: beef or chicken, about 50 g per batch, well trimmed, finely chopped and cooked with the onion until no pink remains. Strong flavour — it balances well with squash, carrot or beetroot, which are sweet. Once a week is enough: liver concentrates vitamin A and should not become a daily habit.

Texture by stage

At 6 to 7 months, fork-mashed with recognisable soft pieces — do not blend. At 8 to 9 months, coarsely mashed, pieces around 5 mm, meat fibres visible. At 10 to 12 months, chopped, nearly adult food without salt. After age one it is family food, and salt comes back.

Freezing

Portion it warm into small pots or an ice-cube tray — roughly 30 ml cubes make it easy to build growing portions. Cool fast and freeze the same day, especially batches with leafy greens and beetroot, which are high in nitrate and should not sit out warming for hours. Freezer: 30 days. Fridge: 48 hours. Thaw in the fridge overnight or in a water bath, and reheat once only. Whatever is left on the baby's plate goes in the bin — saliva on the spoon contaminates the rest.

NOTES

- This chapter is a record of what I did at home, not paediatric advice. Starting solids is something to settle with the child's paediatrician — especially allergies, pace and quantities.
- Pressure does not destroy nutrients. The opposite: less time and less water than open cooking means less loss of water-soluble vitamins — and the cooking liquid goes back into the food.
- Iron: meat (or liver) + pulses + leafy greens in the same batch is the best of the series. Citrus fruit for dessert, right after the meal, helps absorption more than the zest inside the pot, which is there for aroma.
- Beetroot stains everything — purée #4 comes out purple and so does the nappy. Normal; warn whoever is on duty.
- Pulse skins: beans and chickpeas properly pressure-cooked release their skins and they vanish in the mashing. Undercooked chickpeas leave little pellets of skin — cook them longer, do not blend them harder.
- One batch a week was the rhythm; a new purée every 4 or 5 days avoids boredom and widens the repertoire.

Morning picnic: one-handed food and a cool box

Two questions rule out most of the menu: does it fit in one hand, and can it wait without changing state? The cold chain does the rest.

Two questions rule out almost everything

The first: can it be eaten standing up, with one hand? A picnic with kids has no table and nobody sits — any dish that needs a fork, knife or plate ties up both hands and becomes friction. Roast chicken is great and fails the test; a wrapped sandwich, a hard-boiled egg, cubed fruit, a chip with dip and a vegetable stick all pass. The second: can it wait without changing state? Whatever turns soggy, wilts, melts or browns between assembly and eating is out, or changes shape — this isn't a safety question, it's a question of still being good. What survives both filters is a short menu, and short is the goal, not a side effect: fewer items means fewer containers, a roomier box, fewer openings and steadier temperature.

THE FILTER IN PRACTICE

IN	OUT	WHY
Individually wrapped sandwich	Sandwich assembled on the spot	Assembling with kids around doesn't happen
Hard-boiled egg, unpeeled	Peeled egg	The shell is the packaging
Cubed fruit, loose grapes	Fruit that needs a knife	A knife at the park is one more step
Thick chip + thick dip	Runny sauce	The chip is the utensil; thin sauce drips and breaks it
Dry cake, no frosting	Frosted cake	Condensed-milk frosting inside the cooler is a mess
Vegetable stick	Salad	Utensil

Cold chain

Plastic bottles frozen the night before replace ice: they're structural ice that doesn't wet anything as it melts, and afterwards they turn into a drink — four bottles hold a medium cooler through a morning that climbs from 16 °C to 29 °C. Everything goes in already cold: a drink at room temperature steals cold from everything else, and it's the easiest mistake to avoid. Packing order, bottom to top, is frozen bottles at the base, then the rigid sandwich container lying flat, then dips and eggs, fruit on top; bread, cake and chips stay outside the cooler, because it crushes them and its air is damp. And open it as little as possible: take out only what will be eaten now, not the whole container — whatever comes out and isn't eaten doesn't go back in.

Night-before sequencing

The rule that organizes the night before: whatever is dry gets made the night before, whatever needs water and is better fresh gets made in the morning. The night before: assembling sandwiches, spreads, hard-boiled eggs, cake, anything that needs a food

processor; morning: washing and cutting fruit, mashing guacamole, coffee. This isn't just division of labor — on a night when the street's water was cut off, this is what saved the plan: assembling the sandwiches, the longest single block, doesn't use a drop. For a 6am departure, the morning block has to fit into 15 to 25 minutes; anything longer means something got pushed into the wrong slot.

Reusing water

When water runs short, the water the eggs boiled in is sterile and works for washing hands, knives and cutting boards between steps — the ice-bath water doesn't: it rinsed the shells, where salmonella lives, and shouldn't touch anything that goes raw into a mouth. One basin serves all the vegetables, from cleanest to dirtiest — leaves, herbs, thin-skinned fruit, thick-skinned fruit, roots — and about 2.5 liters cover the whole day. Paper towel saves water: it dries leaves, dries grated vegetables, wipes the board between ingredients.

NOTES

- A menu gets pruned, not piled on: be wary of a menu that only grows. This one started with roast chicken, cold farofa, molho alemão, a savory pie and crudités, and arrived at the park with sandwiches, eggs, two dips with chips, fruit and cake — every cut had a reason (utensil, water, oven, sleep).
- The blender pie is the classic trap: it looks quick, but the filling needs sautéing, draining and cooling, and the whole pie needs another 40 minutes cooling before it slices without crumbling — it's ninety minutes disguised as twenty.
- A flaky oven doesn't belong on the critical path: if the equipment is what might fail, it can't be the thing the whole menu depends on.
- Sleep is an ingredient: a night that ends after midnight with a 5:15am alarm charges interest on the road. Cutting one item is worth more than gaining fifteen morning minutes — and a late start is cheap: leaving at 6:50 instead of 6:00 changes nothing about a morning at the park.
- Calibrated on a real morning: Parque da Criança, Jundiaí, 6 adults and 6 kids, leaving São Paulo at 6am.

TECHNIQUE · MOTHER SAUCE · THE RATIO DEFINES THE USE

Béchamel

Butter, flour and milk — what changes between a runny sauce and a lasagna topping is just the ratio. It thickens when it boils, not before.

Roux: cooking the flour before the milk

Melted butter and flour in equal parts by weight, cooked together until it becomes a smooth paste that bubbles and smells like biscuit — about 2 minutes over medium-low heat, stirring constantly. Less than that leaves a raw-flour taste; more than that darkens the roux and it thickens less.

Warm or cold milk, never both hot

Two combinations avoid lumps: warm milk added gradually to a hot roux, or cold milk added to a roux taken off the heat. What causes lumps is hot milk poured all at once into a hot roux — pick one of the two methods and don't mix them. The first two ladles of milk form a thick paste that needs beating smooth before the next; from there, the rest goes in a thin stream, always stirring and scraping the corners of the pot, where lumps hide.

THE RATIO DEFINES THE USE

RATIO (BUTTER / FLOUR / MILK)	RESULT	USE
60 g / 60 g / 1 L	Runny sauce	For coating/saucing
80 g / 80 g / 1 L	Coats and browns without running	Lasagna topping (the standard here)
100 g / 100 g / 1 L	Very thick	Croquette base

It boils to thicken

The sauce only truly thickens once it comes to a boil — don't judge the consistency before that. Medium heat, stirring the bottom, until it bubbles; then 3 to 5 more minutes on low heat, to finish cooking the flour's starch.

Fixing the consistency

Lumps are fixed with a sieve or an immersion blender, no drama. Too thick calls for more warm milk in a stream, still over heat; too thin calls for more simmering time, or a little extra roux made separately. Season last — salt, freshly grated nutmeg and a little pepper — and taste knowing that, in a lasagna, the cheese and ham are already salty: the béchamel should land a notch under what you'd eat by the spoonful.

NOTES

- It doesn't keep well more than 2 days in the fridge: it curdles and separates on reheating unless it's whisked first.
- If it's not used right away, plastic wrap pressed directly onto the surface stops a skin from forming. Warm it and whisk before using.
- Cold milk works just as well as warm, as long as the roux is off the heat when it goes in — what doesn't work is mixing the two methods.

PART TWO

Recipes

Each recipe as running text and as a cooking table. The table shows at a glance what happens in parallel.

Chicken thighs in the skillet

Glassy skin, juicy meat, finished in butter with garlic and herbs.

SERVES **2 servings** ACTIVE **30 min** TOTAL **55 min** VESSEL **Heavy-bottomed skillet**

INGREDIENTS

- **4** bone-in, skin-on chicken thighs — ~180 g each
- **1 tsp** salt — coarse, ground fresh
- **1 tsp** dried herbs — thyme, rosemary or oregano
- **½ tsp** black pepper — freshly ground
- **1 tbsp** olive oil or neutral oil — just to coat the base
- **1 tbsp** butter — to finish
- **2 cloves** garlic — smashed, skin on
- **2 sprigs** fresh rosemary or thyme — optional

METHOD

1. Take the chicken out of the fridge 20 minutes ahead. Season with salt, dried herbs and pepper.
2. Dry the skin thoroughly with paper towel. If the chicken has been marinating, this step is mandatory — the marinade leaves the skin soaked.
3. In the cold pan, add a thin film of oil, just enough to coat the base. Lay the thighs skin side down and only then turn on medium-low heat.
4. Brown for 12 to 15 minutes without moving or poking. Put a weight on top — another pan, a saucepan of water — to guarantee full contact between skin and pan.
5. Flip the pieces. Another 5 to 6 minutes on the meat side.
6. Add the butter, smashed garlic and rosemary or thyme sprigs. Tilt the pan and baste the meat with the foaming butter for 1 minute.
7. Rest 5 minutes before serving. Doneness: 75 °C at the centre, checked with a thermometer that isn't touching the bone — the bone pulling free easily is just a bonus sign.

COOKING TABLE

DRY THE SKIN THOROUGHLY BEFORE YOU START						
4 bone-in, skin-on chicken thighs — ~180 g each	**season and dry** 20 min out of the fridge · paper towel	**cold pan, skin side down** only then turn on medium-low heat	**brown without moving** 12–15 min · with a weight on top	**flip** 5–6 min on the meat side	**finish in butter** 1 min · basting with a spoon	**rest** 5 min · 75 °C at the centre
1 tsp salt — coarse, ground fresh						
1 tsp dried herbs — thyme, rosemary or oregano						
½ tsp black pepper — freshly ground						
1 tbsp olive oil or neutral oil — just to coat the base						
1 tbsp butter — to finish						
2 cloves garlic — smashed, skin on						
2 sprigs fresh rosemary or thyme — optional						

NOTES

- The fat left in the pan is an ingredient, not mess: it goes into the potatoes or the garlic rice.
- Avoid sugary seasonings (honey, soy, barbecue) — they burn before the skin is done.
- Without a weight, the skin buckles and browns only at the edges.

Chicken thighs in the air fryer

Almost as good as the skillet, for a tenth of the work. No flipping.

SERVES **2 servings** ACTIVE **5 min** TOTAL **30 min** VESSEL **Air fryer**

INGREDIENTS

- **4** bone-in, skin-on chicken thighs
- **1 tsp** salt
- **1 tsp** dried herbs — or lemon pepper, or paprika
- **½ tsp** black pepper — freshly ground
- **1 tsp** olive oil — optional, a drizzle

METHOD

1. Season the thighs with salt, herbs and pepper. Dry the skin well with paper towel.
2. Arrange them in the basket skin up, not touching — if you crowd it, air cannot circulate and the skin steams.
3. Air fryer at 180 °C for 25 minutes. Do not flip, do not open.
4. Rest 5 minutes. Very good — just slightly less glassy than the skillet version.

COOKING TABLE

SKIN UP · DON'T CROWD THE BASKET				
4 bone-in, skin-on chicken thighs	**season and dry** paper towel on the skin	**in the basket, skin up** pieces not touching	**cook at 180 °C** 25 min · no flipping	**rest** 5 min
1 tsp salt				
1 tsp dried herbs — or lemon pepper, or paprika				
½ tsp black pepper — freshly ground				
1 tsp olive oil — optional, a drizzle				

NOTES

- If the air fryer is small, do two batches rather than stacking.
- A drizzle of oil helps browning, but is not needed: the skin's own fat is enough.

Chicken thighs in the oven

A rack over the tray is what separates crisp skin from chicken stewed in its own juices.

SERVES **4 servings** ACTIVE **10 min** TOTAL **50 min** VESSEL **Roasting tray with rack**

INGREDIENTS

- **8** bone-in, skin-on chicken thighs
- **2 tsp** salt
- **2 tsp** dried herbs
- **1 tsp** black pepper — freshly ground
- **1 tsp** paprika — optional

METHOD

1. Preheat the oven to 220 °C. Season and dry the skin well.
2. Arrange the pieces on a rack set in the tray, skin up. Without the rack, the piece roasts in its own fat and the underside skin never crisps.
3. Roast 35 to 40 minutes, without turning, until the skin glazes.
4. Rest 5 minutes before serving.

COOKING TABLE

AIR HAS TO CIRCULATE UNDERNEATH				
8 bone-in, skin-on chicken thighs	**season and dry** paper towel on the skin	**rack over the tray** skin up, spaced apart	**roast at 220 °C** 35–40 min	**rest** 5 min
2 tsp salt				
2 tsp dried herbs				
1 tsp black pepper — freshly ground				
1 tsp paprika — optional				

NOTES

- The fat that drips into the tray is gold: strain it and keep it in the fridge for up to a week.
- A fan oven speeds this up: start checking at 30 minutes.

Potatoes in chicken fat

Made right after the chicken, in the rendered fat, while the meat rests.

SERVES **2 servings** ACTIVE **20 min** TOTAL **25 min** VESSEL **The chicken pan**

INGREDIENTS

- **500 g** potatoes — in 2 cm cubes
- **2 tbsp** rendered chicken fat — whatever is left in the pan
- **2 cloves** garlic — sliced
- **1 sprig** rosemary — optional
- **½ tsp** salt — only at the end

METHOD

1. Cut the potatoes into 2 cm cubes and dry them with paper towel — wet potato does not brown, it boils.
2. Take the chicken out and leave the rendered fat. If there is little left, top up with oil until the base is coated.
3. Put the cubes in a single layer, not stacked, over medium-high heat. If they do not fit at once, do two batches.
4. Brown for 12 to 15 minutes, stirring as little as possible — every stir interrupts the crust that is forming.
5. In the last 2 minutes, add the sliced garlic and rosemary. Salt only now: salting earlier draws out water and softens them.

COOKING TABLE

DON'T WASH THE PAN — THE FAT IS THE SEASONING				
500 g potatoes — in 2 cm cubes	**cut and dry** 2 cm cubes · paper towel	**into the hot fat** single layer, no stacking	**brown** 12–15 min · stir rarely	**garlic, herbs and salt** 2 min at the end
2 tbsp rendered chicken fat — whatever is left in the pan				
2 cloves garlic — sliced				
1 sprig rosemary — optional				
½ tsp salt — only at the end				

NOTES

- To speed things up: boil the cubes 6 min in salted water, drain, dry, then brown. The crust is even better.
- To cut the richness, a leaf salad with plain lime and salt — no oil, the fat already came from the chicken.

05 · CHICKEN · ONE POT · 20 MINUTES

Garlic rice in rendered fat

One spoonful of chicken fat instead of oil changes the whole pot of rice.

SERVES **4 servings** ACTIVE **10 min** TOTAL **25 min** VESSEL **Saucepan with lid**

INGREDIENTS

- **2 cups** white rice — rinsed and drained
- **2 tbsp** rendered chicken fat
- **4 cloves** garlic — thinly sliced
- **3 cups** hot water
- **1 tsp** salt

METHOD

1. Heat the rendered fat and fry the sliced garlic to pale gold. Dark garlic makes the whole pot bitter — take it off sooner than seems necessary.
2. Add the rinsed, drained rice. Toast 2 minutes, until the grains turn translucent at the edges.
3. Add the hot water and salt. Boil uncovered until the water disappears from the surface and craters appear.
4. Cover, drop to the lowest heat and count 15 minutes. Do not open the pot in that time.
5. Turn it off and rest 5 minutes still covered. Fluff with a fork, never a spoon.

COOKING TABLE

HOT WATER — RICE DOES NOT LIKE THERMAL SHOCK					
2 cups white rice — rinsed and drained					
2 tbsp rendered chicken fat	**fry the garlic** 2 min · to pale gold	**toast the rice** 2 min · grains translucent	**water and salt, boil** uncovered, until the surface dries	**cover, low heat** 15 min · do not open	**rest and fluff** 5 min covered · fork
4 cloves garlic — thinly sliced					
3 cups hot water					
1 tsp salt					

NOTES

- Ratio 1 part rice to 1½ water. With animal fat in the base, the grains stay looser than with oil.
- Strained chicken fat keeps a week in the fridge and three months in the freezer.

Prime rib on the griddle

Sear hard, then minimum heat flipping every minute — the griddle becomes an oven.

SERVES **1 serving** ACTIVE **25 min** TOTAL **45 min** VESSEL **Removable griddle over the big burner**

INGREDIENTS

- **1 piece** prime rib — ~4 cm thick
- **1 tbsp** coarse salt — generous, only at the last moment
- **1 tsp** lard or oil — thin film on the griddle
- **½ tsp** black pepper — only after searing

METHOD

1. Dry thoroughly with paper towel and leave it 30 to 40 minutes out of the fridge. A cold centre is the biggest enemy.
2. Preheat the griddle 5 to 8 minutes on low-medium so the heat spreads. The flame concentrates in the centre, so sear there. Test with a drop of water: it should skitter and vanish in 1 to 2 seconds.
3. Generous salt only now. A thin film of lard or oil on the hot griddle.
4. Sear 2 to 3 minutes per side, until a good crust forms.
5. Drop to minimum heat and flip every minute for another 6 to 10 minutes, depending on doneness. Frequent flipping cooks the centre evenly.
6. Sear the fat edges upright, about 30 seconds, holding with tongs. Black pepper now — earlier it burns.
7. From 6 minutes into the low-heat phase, make a small cut in the centre and look: medium-rare is warm pink; cold red needs more time.
8. Rest 8 to 10 minutes. A thick cut needs that time to redistribute its juices.

COOKING TABLE

A WATER DROP SKITTERS AND VANISHES IN 1–2 SECONDS						
1 piece prime rib — ~4 cm thick	**dry and temper** paper towel · 30–40 min out of the fridge	**salt at the last moment** generous, only as it goes on	**sear on the hot griddle** 2–3 min per side	**minimum heat, flip every minute** 6–10 min · cut and peek	**sear the fat edges** 30 s upright, with tongs	**rest** 8–10 min
1 tbsp coarse salt — generous, only at the last moment						
1 tsp lard or oil — thin film on the griddle						
½ tsp black pepper — only after searing						

NOTES

- A thin cut (~2 cm) is a different method: 2 to 2.5 minutes per side flipping once only, 20–30 min out of the fridge, 5 min rest. Every extra 30 seconds changes the doneness.
- Pan sauce: return the griddle to low heat and deglaze with a little cachaça or soy sauce plus butter. If it has soy, ease off the salt elsewhere on the plate.
- Use the removable griddle, not the built-in one: the big burner has better heat recovery.

Smashed potatoes in the air fryer

Cracks and loose edges are what turn crisp. Don't tidy them up.

SERVES **2 servings** ACTIVE **15 min** TOTAL **40 min** VESSEL **Air fryer**

INGREDIENTS

- **4** medium potatoes — whole, skin on
- **1 tbsp** coarse salt — for the water
- **3 tbsp** lard or olive oil — on both sides
- **1 pinch** fine salt — light, on top
- **1 sprig** rosemary

METHOD

1. Boil the potatoes whole in well-salted water until a fork slides in easily, about 20 minutes.
2. Drain and let them dry for 2 to 3 minutes, steaming off.
3. Smash each one with the base of a glass to about 1.5 cm. Cracks and ragged edges are what turn crisp — do not reshape them if they fall apart.
4. Generous fat on both sides, including the loose bits. Light salt on top (the water already seasoned the inside) and rosemary.
5. Air fryer at 200 °C for 15 to 18 minutes, no flipping, no stirring. Small basket: two batches of two potatoes — piled up they will not crisp.

COOKING TABLE

TOO LITTLE FAT IS THE #1 AIR FRYER MISTAKE					
4 medium potatoes — whole, skin on	**boil whole** well-salted water · ~20 min	**drain and dry** 2–3 min letting steam off	**smash with the base of a glass** to ~1.5 cm · cracks = crunch	**fat, salt and rosemary** both sides, including the loose bits	**air fryer 200 °C** 15–18 min · no flipping, no stirring
1 tbsp coarse salt — for the water					
3 tbsp lard or olive oil — on both sides					
1 pinch fine salt — light, on top					
1 sprig rosemary					

NOTES

- Overcooked potato releases more moisture: compensate with more fat.
- If they have to wait, 2 to 3 minutes back in the air fryer re-crisps them.
- An oven for four potatoes is a waste — the air fryer's circulation crisps them even better.

Pork tenderloin medallions in mustard sauce

A lean cut: sear only for the crust and let the sauce finish the cooking slowly.

SERVES **2 servings** ACTIVE **30 min** TOTAL **35 min** VESSEL **Heavy stainless or cast iron**

INGREDIENTS

- **650 g** pork tenderloin — 2 whole loins, in 2.5 cm medallions
- **1 tsp** salt — light — the soy sauce already salts
- **½ tsp** black pepper — freshly ground
- **1 tbsp** oil
- **2 tbsp** cold butter — half at the start, half at the end
- **1 clove** garlic — smashed
- **2 tbsp** cachaça
- **1 tbsp** Dijon mustard
- **1 tbsp** soy sauce
- **100 ml** heavy cream

METHOD

1. Cut the medallions about 2.5 cm thick. What governs doneness is thickness, not diameter — if some come out wider, fine. Fold the thin tail back on itself and pin it with a toothpick to match the height.
2. Dry thoroughly with paper towel. Wet meat steams instead of browning. Season with salt and pepper only as it goes into the pan.
3. Hot pan with the oil. Lay them out without crowding — if the pan is thin-bottomed, sear in small batches and let it recover between them.
4. Sear 2 minutes, flip, 2 more minutes — only until golden crust on both sides. The centre stays raw on purpose. Remove and set aside on a plate.
5. Drop to medium heat. Add half the butter and the smashed garlic; cook just until fragrant — on this burner garlic burns in seconds.
6. Take the pan off the heat and add the cachaça (alcohol in a very hot pan can ignite). Return to the heat and scrape the base to lift the fond.
7. Add the mustard, soy sauce and cream. Stir and reduce over low heat until it thickens and coats the back of a spoon.
8. Turn off the heat and whisk in the remaining cold butter for shine.
9. Return the medallions and any juices they released; warm gently just to finish cooking. Pale pink with pink juices means done. Taste the sauce before adjusting salt.

COOKING TABLE

SEAR WITH THE CENTRE STILL RAW — THE SAUCE FINISHES IT							
650 g pork tenderloin — 2 whole loins, in 2.5 cm medallions	**cut 2.5 cm and dry** fold the thin tail and pin it	**season at the last moment** light salt and pepper	**sear and remove** 2 min · flip · 2 min · raw centre				**return the meat** warm gently · taste for salt
1 tsp salt — light — the soy sauce already salts							
½ tsp black pepper — freshly ground							
1 tbsp oil							
2 tbsp cold butter — half at the start, half at the end				**butter and garlic** just until fragrant	**off the heat: cachaça** return and scrape the fond	**mustard, soy and cream** reduce until it coats the spoon	
1 clove garlic — smashed							
2 tbsp cachaça							
1 tbsp Dijon mustard							
1 tbsp soy sauce							
100 ml heavy cream							

NOTES

- Avoid non-stick: it barely builds fond, and the sauce comes out flat.
- Classic variation: swap the soy for an extra pinch of salt and go heavier on the mustard. Light variation: skip the cream and make only the cachaça reduction with cold butter.
- Sides: white rice, mash or browned potatoes, and bread for the sauce.

Marinated flap steak in the oven

Served hot, medium-well, sliced thin against the grain as it goes to the table.

SERVES **4 servings** ACTIVE **20 min** TOTAL **3h05** VESSEL **Roasting tray and foil**

INGREDIENTS

- **1.2 kg** flap steak (bavette) — whole cut
- salt
- soy sauce
- Worcestershire sauce
- fish sauce
- vinegar
- beer
- bay leaf
- black pepper
- allspice

METHOD

1. Mix the marinade: salt, soy sauce, Worcestershire, fish sauce, vinegar, beer, bay, black pepper and allspice. That is four sources of sodium at once — set a portion aside before the meat goes in, and taste only that reserved portion.
2. Marinate 2 hours in the fridge.
3. Take it out of the fridge 1 hour before it goes in the oven. A cold centre is the biggest enemy without a thermometer.
4. Dry the surface well with paper towel — the marinade soaks the meat.
5. Cover with foil and put it in the oven at 200 °C.
6. Start checking at 45 minutes: cut into the thickest point and read the colour. Cold red in the centre means keep going; warm pink is rare to medium-rare; barely pink, almost none, still moist is medium-well — the target. Even grey is well done and there is no going back.
7. Near the target, take off the foil and turn on the grill just to colour the surface.
8. Rest 8 to 10 minutes before slicing. Do not skip this.
9. Bring the whole hot cut to the table and slice it there, very thin and against the grain — it is the single biggest factor in this cut's tenderness.

COOKING TABLE

THE MARINADE HAS FOUR SOURCES OF SODIUM — SET SOME ASIDE BEFORE IT TOUCHES THE MEAT AND TASTE ONLY THAT PART						
1.2 kg flap steak (bavette) — whole cut						
salt	**mix the marinade** set some aside before the meat and taste only that	**marinate 2 h** refrigerated	**1 h out of the fridge** and dry the surface well	**covered with foil, 200 °C** start checking at 45 min	**foil off + grill** just to colour	**rest and slice** 8–10 min · thin, against the grain
soy sauce						
Worcestershire sauce						
fish sauce						
vinegar						
beer						
bay leaf						
black pepper						
allspice						

NOTES

- Approximate total: 50 to 65 minutes in the oven for a ~1.2 kg cut at 200 °C.
- Optional sauce from the liquid the raw meat sat in: bring it to a full boil for at least 5 minutes before reducing — only then taste for salt, since reducing intensifies it considerably.
- Reheating destroys it: medium flap steak that goes back on the heat turns to rubber. If you cannot serve immediately, braise instead (150–160 °C, 2.5–3 h with liquid covering) or serve it as cold roast beef.

Roasted short rib (chuck rib)

Half an hour at full oven heat builds the crust; five hours sealed in foil melt the bone loose.

> Two phases that never mix: crust in a maxed-out oven, uncovered, half an hour — the only window in which the surface browns, because once sealed in foil the environment turns to steam and nothing colours further. Then a five-hour braise at low heat, until the collagen turns to gelatine and the bone pulls free. The mustard is not there for flavour, it is glue: it holds the seasoning on the surface through the thermal shock, and what is left of it at the end is just a sharp note in the broth.

SERVES **6–8 servings per 2 kg cut** ACTIVE **60 min** TOTAL **5h40** VESSEL **Large roasting tray and foil**

INGREDIENTS

- **1 piece** short rib (chuck rib), whole piece — whole cut
- mustard — enough to coat the whole surface
- **40 g** medium or coarse salt — 2% of the cut's weight
- sugar — just a pinch, to caramelise
- dried herbs — to taste
- black pepper — freshly ground
- baby potatoes — onion and whatever else is on hand, to roast alongside
- onion
- white wine — for the base of the tray — or water, or nothing
- **2** sheets of foil — two layers

METHOD

1. Coat the whole surface of the cut with mustard, by hand — thin and even, a film, not a layer.
2. Season over the mustard: salt (2% of the cut's weight), sugar, dried herbs and black pepper. The coarse salt stays visible on the surface, and that is correct.
3. Full oven heat (270 °C), uncovered, fat side up, 30 minutes. Check at 20: if the sugar is already darkening too much, take it out early.
4. Take the tray out of the oven. Scatter the baby potatoes and onion around the cut. Wet just the base with white wine (or water), without drowning it.
5. Cover with two layers of foil, sealed tight against the edges of the tray. A real seal is what makes the five hours work.
6. Drop the oven to 150 °C and roast for 5 hours, without opening it.
7. Check for doneness only when you open it, at the end of the five hours: the bone should turn freely and a fork should meet no resistance. Opening earlier costs the seal and the heat the recipe depends on.
8. Rest 10 minutes before serving.

COOKING TABLE

NOTHING BROWNS AFTER THE FOIL GOES ON — ALL THE COLOUR COMES FROM THE FIRST 30 MINUTES							
1 piece short rib (chuck rib), whole piece — whole cut	**coat** a thin film of mustard, by hand						**rest** 10 min before serving
mustard — enough to coat the whole surface							
40 g medium or coarse salt — 2% of the cut's weight		**season** 2% salt, a pinch of sugar, herbs, pepper	**crust 30 min** 270 °C, uncovered · check at 20				
sugar — just a pinch, to caramelise				**vegetables and base** around the cut · just wet the base			
dried herbs — to taste					**seal** two layers, sealed tight at the edges		
black pepper — freshly ground						**braise 5 h** 150 °C, sealed · do not open	
baby potatoes — onion and whatever else is on hand, to roast alongside							
onion							
white wine — for the base of the tray — or water, or nothing							
2 sheets of foil — two layers							

NOTES

- Nothing browns after the foil goes on: all the colour comes from the first 30 minutes. If it comes out pale from that phase, waiting will not fix it — it will not brown any further.
- 2% salt works because nothing gets discarded: the potatoes, onion and liquid all share the salt over the five hours. The same ratio on a dry roasted-and-sliced cut would be far too salty.
- The seal matters more than the liquid: with the foil sealed tight, the cut releases enough of its own juices. Too much liquid in the base boils the potatoes instead of roasting them.
- Do not open it partway through: every opening breaks the two-layer seal, which never re-seals the same way, and drops the oven temperature.
- 150 °C, not 160 °C: inside the sealed foil the environment already sits around 100 °C from the steam — what the oven temperature changes is speed, and how hard it pushes the edges. At 160 °C the potatoes and onion overcook before the five hours are up.
- Stovetop backup: the same braise works in a stockpot, with the removable griddle as a heat diffuser over the lowest burner setting — in that case it takes about 4 hours, not 5. The crust is done on the griddle first, and the finish goes into the air fryer at 200 °C for 10 minutes.

Full feijoada

Correct soaking, the right order for the meats, and low heat for 4 to 5 hours. The rest is patience.

SERVES **20 servings** ACTIVE **3 h** TOTAL **30h35** VESSEL **33–36 cm stockpot (~16–18 L)**

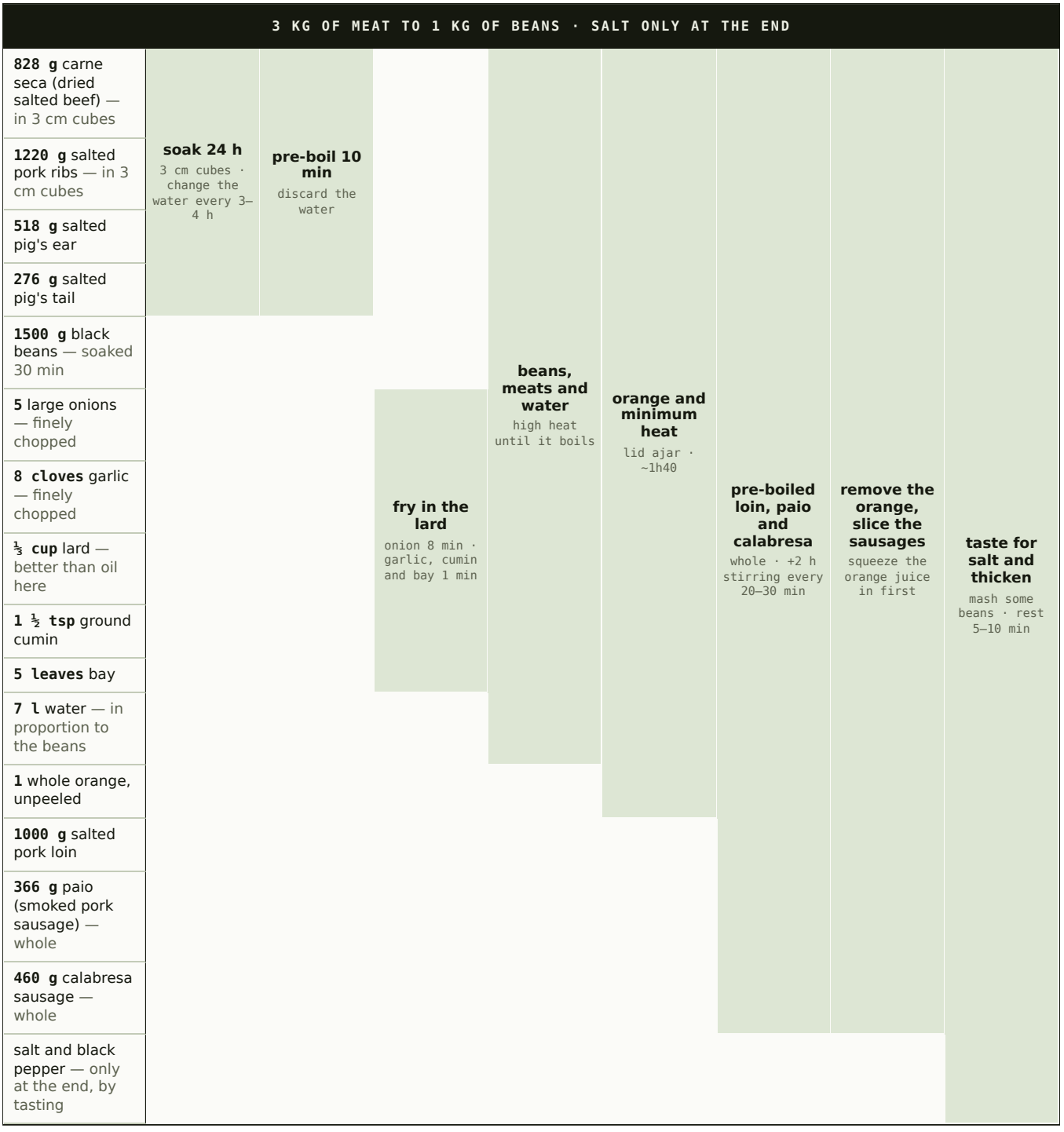
INGREDIENTS

- **828 g** carne seca (dried salted beef) — in 3 cm cubes
- **1220 g** salted pork ribs — in 3 cm cubes
- **518 g** salted pig's ear
- **276 g** salted pig's tail
- **1500 g** black beans — soaked 30 min
- **5** large onions — finely chopped
- **8 cloves** garlic — finely chopped
- **⅓ cup** lard — better than oil here
- **1 ½ tsp** ground cumin
- **5 leaves** bay
- **7 l** water — in proportion to the beans
- **1** whole orange, unpeeled
- **1000 g** salted pork loin
- **366 g** paio (smoked pork sausage) — whole
- **460 g** calabresa sausage — whole
- salt and black pepper — only at the end, by tasting

METHOD

1. Day 1 — Soaking. Cut the salted meats into 3 cm cubes, cover with plenty of water in separate bowls and refrigerate. Change the water every 3 or 4 hours through the day. Twenty-four hours is ideal.
2. Day 2, 5:45 — Pre-boil the salted meats in a pot of water. Ten minutes after it boils, discard the water and set the meats aside.
3. 6:30 — Fry the onion in the lard until golden, about 8 minutes. Add the garlic, cumin and bay and stir for 1 minute. If it catches slightly on the base, fine: fond is flavour, and you deglaze later.
4. 6:50 — Add the beans (soaked 30 min), 6 to 8 litres of water and the pre-boiled meats. High heat until it boils.
5. 7:40 — Once boiling, add the whole orange, drop to minimum heat and leave the lid ajar.
6. 9:20 — Pre-boil the loin separately for 10 minutes and add it to the pot, along with the whole paio and calabresa. No bacon here: all of it goes into the farofa.
7. 9:20 to 11:30 — Stir every 20 or 30 minutes, gently scraping the base. Check the water level: the meats must stay covered. Top up if needed.
8. 10:30 — Take out the orange and squeeze its juice into the pot before discarding it. Leaving it longer turns bitter.
9. 11:50 — Take out the paio and calabresa, cut into 1 cm diagonal slices and return them to the pot.
10. 12:00 — Taste for salt for the first time. It probably needs none. If the broth is thin, mash some beans against the side of the pot with the back of the ladle.
11. 12:20 — Turn it off. Rest 5 to 10 minutes with the lid ajar before serving: the broth finishes thickening.

COOKING TABLE



NOTES

- Feijoada has several sources of salt: the salted meats, the paio, the calabresa. Never salt before tasting at the end.
- 1.5 kg of beans makes it meat-heavy; 2 kg gives more broth to go round. Try 2 kg if the group is over 15.
- All the bacon goes into the farofa: the feijoada already has plenty of fat from paio, calabresa, ribs and loin.
- The total time counts the 24 h soak; the cooking day itself (Day 2) runs about 6h30 from start to the final rest.
- Before it boils: the meats, beans and water easily add up to more than 12–13 L. A 10 L pot is too shallow to stir without spilling — use a bigger one or split it across two pots.
- It freezes very well and improves the next day. Set aside clean containers before serving. To thaw: fridge 24 h ahead, reheat over low heat, stirring.
- Hot sauce: Tabasco is the classic, pickled biquinho peppers the mild crowd-pleaser. Sriracha and sweet chilli do not work — wrong profile.

Bacon farofa with olives

All the bacon from the feijoada ends up here — it goes further as crisp farofa.

SERVES **20 servings** ACTIVE **25 min** TOTAL **25 min** VESSEL **Large skillet**

INGREDIENTS

- **240 g** bacon — in 1 cm cubes
- **1** medium onion — chopped
- **2 cloves** garlic — chopped
- **2 cups** cassava flour — fine or coarse (biju)
- **½ cup** olives — chopped
- **2 tbsp** parsley — chopped
- **½ tsp** black pepper — freshly ground

METHOD

1. Fry the bacon in 1 cm cubes until golden, about 7 minutes. Lift it out with a slotted spoon and set aside.
2. Pour half the fat into a small bowl, for the greens. This step matters — collards in bacon fat are unbeatable.
3. In the remaining fat, fry the chopped onion until golden, about 5 minutes. Add the garlic and cook 1 minute more.
4. Return the bacon to the pan and lower the heat.
5. Add the flour a little at a time, stirring constantly. Toast for 7 to 10 minutes until golden — fine flour needs more toasting than coarse.
6. At the end, add the chopped parsley, olives and freshly ground black pepper. Taste for salt. Keep it covered.

COOKING TABLE

FLOUR A LITTLE AT A TIME, STIRRING CONSTANTLY						
240 g bacon — in 1 cm cubes	**fry the bacon** ~7 min · lift out with a slotted spoon	**set aside half the fat** keep it for the greens	**fry onion and garlic** 5 min + 1 min	**return the bacon, low heat**	**flour bit by bit, toast** 7–10 min · stirring constantly	**parsley, olives and pepper** taste for salt
1 medium onion — chopped						
2 cloves garlic — chopped						
2 cups cassava flour — fine or coarse (biju)						
½ cup olives — chopped						
2 tbsp parsley — chopped						
½ tsp black pepper — freshly ground						

NOTES

- Scrambled egg before the flour makes a deluxe farofa.
- The bacon is the only source of fat here, and it is plenty — do not add oil.

Collard greens in bacon fat

Two to three minutes in the pan. Past that point, it's gone.

SERVES **20 servings** ACTIVE **15 min** TOTAL **15 min** VESSEL **Very hot skillet**

INGREDIENTS

- **3 bunches** collard greens — chiffonade, 2–3 mm
- **2 tbsp** bacon fat — the one you saved from the farofa
- **1 clove** garlic — chopped
- **½ tsp** salt — at the end

METHOD

1. Stack the leaves, roll them tight and slice very thin — 2 to 3 mm, with a knife. A processor bruises the leaf, cuts unevenly and oxidises it.
2. Very hot skillet with the reserved bacon fat and the chopped garlic.
3. Throw in the greens and stir fast for 2 to 3 minutes. Salt at the end. It must not overcook: it has to stay vivid green.

COOKING TABLE

IT HAS TO COME OUT VIVID GREEN			
3 bunches collard greens — chiffonade, 2–3 mm	**fine chiffonade** stack, roll tight, slice 2–3 mm		
2 tbsp bacon fat — the one you saved from the farofa		**very hot skillet** fat and garlic	**sauté** 2–3 min · stirring fast
1 clove garlic — chopped			
½ tsp salt — at the end			

NOTES

- It is the last thing to leave the kitchen, immediately before serving.
- No feijoada that day? Bacon fat kept in the fridge does the same job.

Ragù alla bolognese

A meat ragù, not a tomato sauce with meat in it — the body comes from a long-sweated soffritto and meat fried in its own fat, not from the tomato.

> Based on a recipe from an Italian cookbook that uses just one spoonful of tomato paste for 255 g of meat: tomato is a supporting player. Quadrupling it to 1 kg of mixed meat (half beef, half pork — pork brings fat and sweetness, beef brings depth), the simmer time doesn't change, still 1h30; what changes is the time to brown the meat, which needs a wide pot and, with 1 kg, two batches — otherwise the meat steams instead of browning.

SERVES **~2.5 L — enough for two lasagna pans** ACTIVE **40 min** TOTAL **130 min**

VESSEL **Heavy, wide pot, with a heat diffuser**

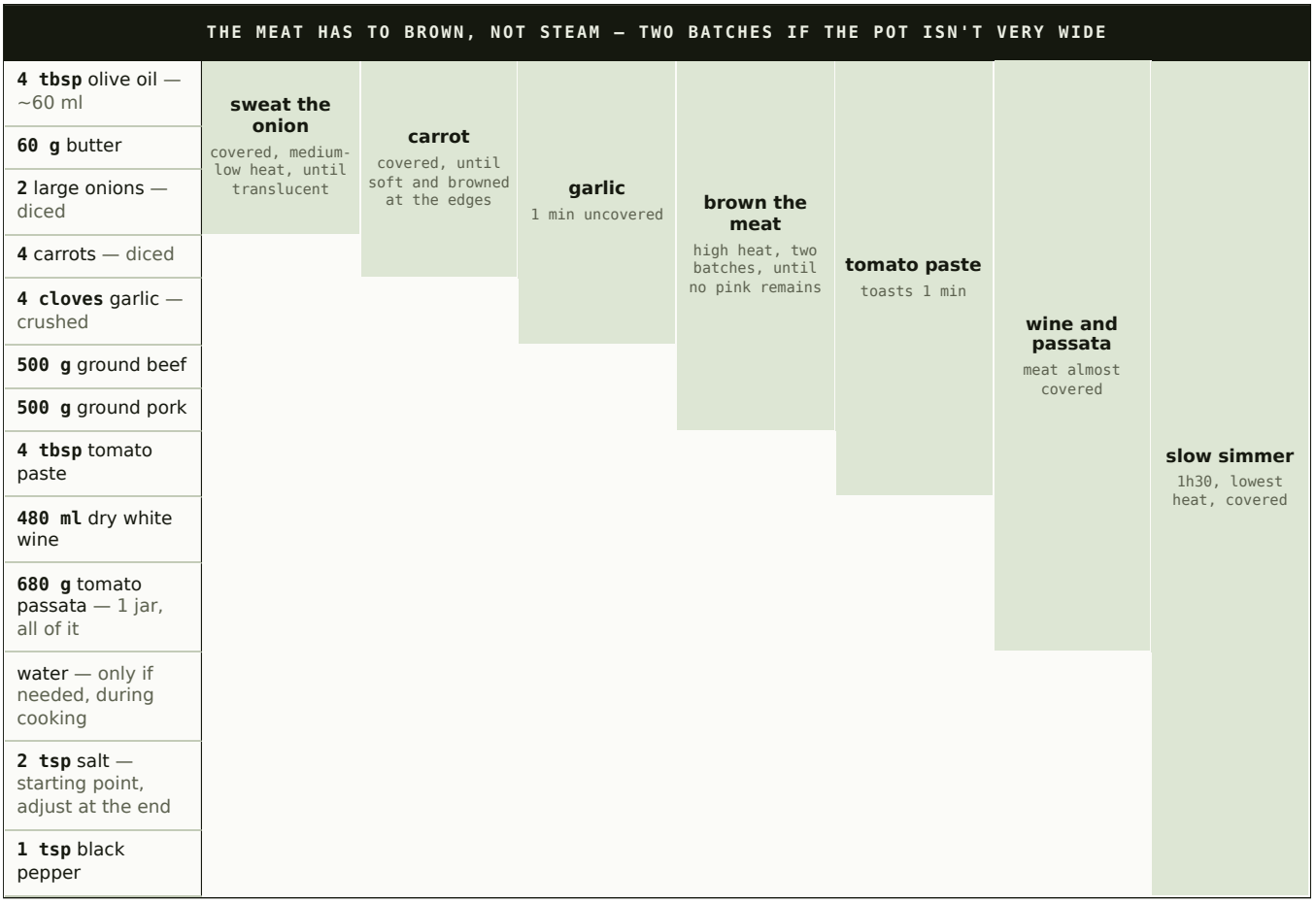
INGREDIENTS

- **4 tbsp** olive oil — ~60 ml
- **60 g** butter
- **2** large onions — diced
- **4** carrots — diced
- **4 cloves** garlic — crushed
- **500 g** ground beef
- **500 g** ground pork
- **4 tbsp** tomato paste
- **480 ml** dry white wine
- **680 g** tomato passata — 1 jar, all of it
- water — only if needed, during cooking
- **2 tsp** salt — starting point, adjust at the end
- **1 tsp** black pepper

METHOD

1. Oil and butter in the heavy, wide pot. Onion, cover and medium-low heat, 5 to 10 minutes until translucent, stirring every 2 minutes.
2. Carrot, cover again, 5 to 10 more minutes, until soft and starting to brown at the edges.
3. Garlic, 1 minute uncovered.
4. High heat. Break up the meat with a wooden spoon — with 1 kg, two batches if the pot isn't very wide, so it fries instead of steaming. It's ready when it loses its pink color and starts sizzling in its own fat, 10 to 15 minutes per batch.
5. Tomato paste, mixing and toasting for 1 minute.
6. Wine and the passata. Salt and pepper. The meat should be almost covered in liquid.
7. Lowest heat with the heat diffuser, covered, simmering slowly, 1h30. The passata has sugar and solids that stick more than water — stir the bottom every 20 minutes; it will probably only need water in the last half hour, if at all.
8. Ready for lasagna when the sauce runs off the spoon but doesn't pool. If it's watery, uncover it for the last 20 to 30 minutes. Adjust the salt at the end.

COOKING TABLE



NOTES

- The version faithful to the cookbook (for long pasta like tagliatelle) swaps the passata for celery in the soffritto (4 stalks) and for water instead of passata (480 ml wine + 480 ml water, plus up to 480 ml more if it dries out) — it comes out drier and meatier, without the passata's sweetness.
- Passata doesn't replace the tomato paste: it isn't concentrated and doesn't give the toasted flavor of the paste step — both go in, one doesn't substitute for the other.
- The cookbook suggests variations: half veal and half pork; or beef with a crumbled skinless Italian sausage; or 225 g of sliced mushrooms fried in butter, added half an hour before the end (book quantities, for 255 g of meat — adjust proportionally).
- Made the day before is better, and the fat rises and hardens in the fridge, making it easy to skim off before assembling the lasagna.
- Onion: 2 large ones equal about 4 medium ones. For a meatier ragù, 3 medium onions are enough, keeping the carrot the same.

Ham, cheese and bolognese lasagna, topped with béchamel

Layers of pasta, ragù, ham and cheese; béchamel on top only, torched at the end to brown without relying on the oven's broiler.

> Two things hold the structure together: the ragù, wet enough to hydrate the pasta in the oven, and the ham with cheese as a dry layer that gives a clean cut. The béchamel stays on top only — the inside is pure ragù, meatier and less creamy than a lasagna with béchamel between every layer. The torch does what the oven does poorly: brown the top fast, without drying out the middle or depending on the broiler.

SERVES **1 pan (~10 servings)** ACTIVE **30 min** TOTAL **95 min** VESSEL **Baking dish and kitchen torch**

INGREDIENTS

- butter — for greasing
- **1.25 l** bolognese ragù — see that recipe
- lasagna pasta — type and amount not recorded — fresh, pre-cooked or dried
- **500 g** thinly sliced ham
- sliced cheese (mozzarella or similar) — starting suggestion: 500 g — not confirmed
- **1 l** béchamel (80 g / 80 g / 1 L) — see that recipe
- grated cheese to finish — suggestion: 100 g — not confirmed

METHOD

1. If the ragù was made the day before, take it out of the fridge 1 hour ahead and skim off the solidified fat on top — cold ragù doesn't wet the pasta and leaves the lasagna with hard edges.
2. If the pasta is dried with no pre-cooking, boil it to al dente minus 1 minute and drain on a towel. Fresh or pre-cooked goes in straight — in that case the ragù needs to be quite loose.
3. Grease the dish and spread a thin ladle of ragù on the bottom, just so the pasta doesn't stick.
4. Build the layers, 3 to 4 times: pasta, ragù spread to the edges, ham without overlapping too much, sliced cheese. On the last layer, pasta topped with a thinner layer of ragù, so the pasta isn't left exposed.
5. Spread the warm béchamel over everything, to the edges — it's what seals it. Grated cheese on top.
6. Cover with foil greased on the inside (so it doesn't stick to the béchamel) and bake at 180 °C for 30 minutes.
7. Uncover and bake 15 to 20 more minutes, until it bubbles at the edges. Check the center with a knife — it should come out hot to the touch.
8. Rest 15 minutes out of the oven before torching and cutting — without this, the lasagna falls apart when sliced.
9. Torch on medium flame, 10–15 cm away, in continuous motion, until the cheesy béchamel gets golden patches and dark bubbles at the high points — don't linger on one spot, or it burns before browning around it. Cut with a large knife, into pieces of about 8 × 10 cm, with a spatula underneath.

COOKING TABLE

NEVER COLD RAGÙ AT ASSEMBLY — IT CHILLS THE PASTA AND HARDENS THE EDGE					
butter — for greasing					
1.25 l bolognese ragù — see that recipe	**ragù at the right temperature** warmed, never cold				
lasagna pasta — type and amount not recorded — fresh, pre-cooked or dried		**pasta** al dente minus 1 min, if dried	**layers** pasta, ragù, ham, cheese — 3 to 4 times	**topping** warm béchamel to the edges, grated cheese	**oven and torch** 180 °C covered 30 min + 15–20 min uncovered, then torch
500 g thinly sliced ham					
sliced cheese (mozzarella or similar) — starting suggestion: 500 g — not confirmed					
1 l béchamel (80 g / 80 g / 1 L) — see that recipe					
grated cheese to finish — suggestion: 100 g — not confirmed					

NOTES

- Béchamel on top only is the house's choice. For a creamier version, use 1.5 L and spread a thin layer over the ragù on every layer too — the slices come out less clean-cut.
- Ham releases water: slice it thin and don't stack it — stacked, it forms a water pocket that softens the pasta.
- If the oven fails, assemble in a dish that can go on the burner and cook it covered on the stovetop, lowest heat with a diffuser, 40 to 50 minutes — the pasta cooks in the ragù's steam. It won't be the same, but it saves dinner; the torch at the end takes care of the top.
- Better 20 minutes out of the oven than straight away. Reheats well in portions, oven at 160 °C covered for 20 minutes, or air fryer as a single piece at 150 °C for 10 minutes.
- Freezes assembled and unbaked, before torching: bake it still cold, 1 hour covered plus 20 minutes uncovered, with the torch at the end.
- The cheese, grated cheese and pasta type haven't been precisely recorded yet — the values here are a starting point, not a tested measurement. Adjust to whatever you actually use.

Bacon and calabresa fried rice

The order is the method: each step uses the fat from the one before.

SERVES **2 servings** ACTIVE **15 min** TOTAL **15 min** VESSEL **Wok or large skillet**

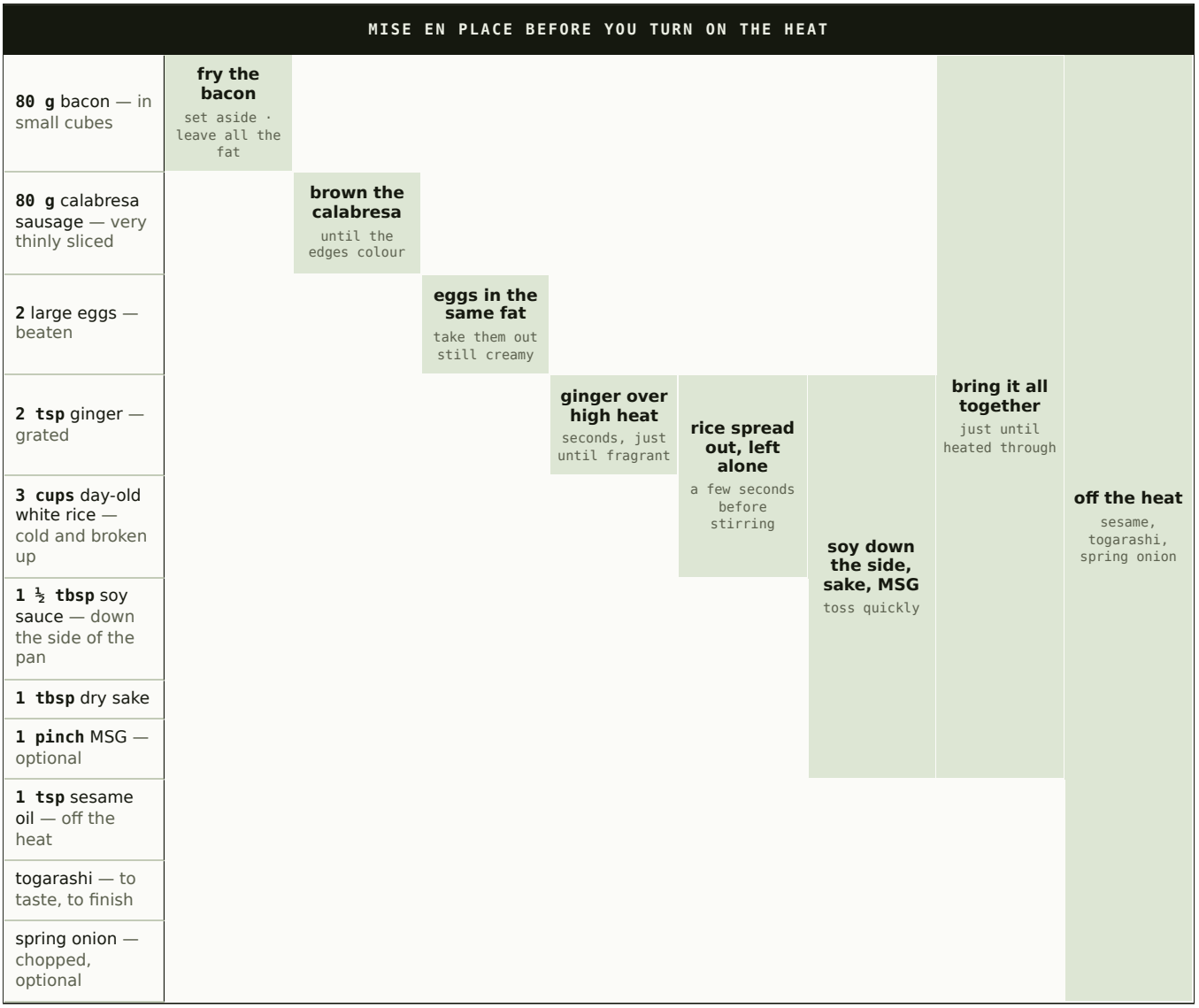
INGREDIENTS

- **80 g** bacon — in small cubes
- **80 g** calabresa sausage — very thinly sliced
- **2** large eggs — beaten
- **2 tsp** ginger — grated
- **3 cups** day-old white rice — cold and broken up
- **1 ½ tbsp** soy sauce — down the side of the pan
- **1 tbsp** dry sake
- **1 pinch** MSG — optional
- **1 tsp** sesame oil — off the heat
- togarashi — to taste, to finish
- spring onion — chopped, optional

METHOD

1. Mise en place first — the stir-fry is too fast to chop halfway through. Break up the rice with your hands, slice the sausage thin, beat the eggs, grate the ginger. Everything within reach before the heat goes on.
2. Almost-dry pan, medium heat. Fry the bacon until it renders and turns golden and crisp. Lift it out with a slotted spoon and leave all the fat in the pan — it is the base of everything.
3. In the bacon fat, brown the sausage until the edges colour. Remove and set aside with the bacon.
4. Pour the beaten eggs into the same fat and stir over medium heat, pulling from the bottom. Take them out still soft and creamy, before they dry — they finish cooking later.
5. Turn the heat up high. Throw in the ginger and stir just until fragrant, without burning it — on this burner that is seconds.
6. In goes the broken-up rice. Spread it in a layer and leave it still for a few seconds to catch on the pan before stirring — that is what gives the toasted bits. Then toss until the grains loosen and colour lightly.
7. Pour the soy sauce down the side of the pan, where it caramelises better than poured over the top. A splash of sake to lift the base, a pinch of MSG. Toss quickly.
8. Return the bacon, sausage and egg. Toss just until heated and the egg breaks into pieces through the rice.
9. Off the heat: a drizzle of sesame oil, togarashi and spring onion. Taste and adjust — it will rarely need salt.

COOKING TABLE



NOTES

- Cold day-old rice is mandatory: the grain has lost moisture and fries loose. Hot fresh rice releases steam and goes soggy.
- Yesterday's rice needs to have cooled properly: spread it in a shallow container as soon as it is cooked, let it stop steaming, and refrigerate within 2 hours. Rice left out warm on the counter overnight will not do — it is classic ground for Bacillus cereus toxin, which does not go away on refrying.
- Bacon brings fat and smoky crunch; the calabresa goes in small amounts only for its paprika and garlic. Without it, compensate with more ginger and soy.
- No miso: in the heat of the pan it clumps, burns and turns to paste. Its place is soup, a marinade or a bowl sauce.
- Four sources of sodium at once — bacon, sausage, soy and MSG. Taste before you even think about salt.

Lime prawn orzo

Pre-cooked prawns only reheat at the end. The hondashi supplies the sea flavour that is missing.

SERVES **2 servings** ACTIVE **25 min** TOTAL **30 min** VESSEL **Large pan, 4–5 cm sides**

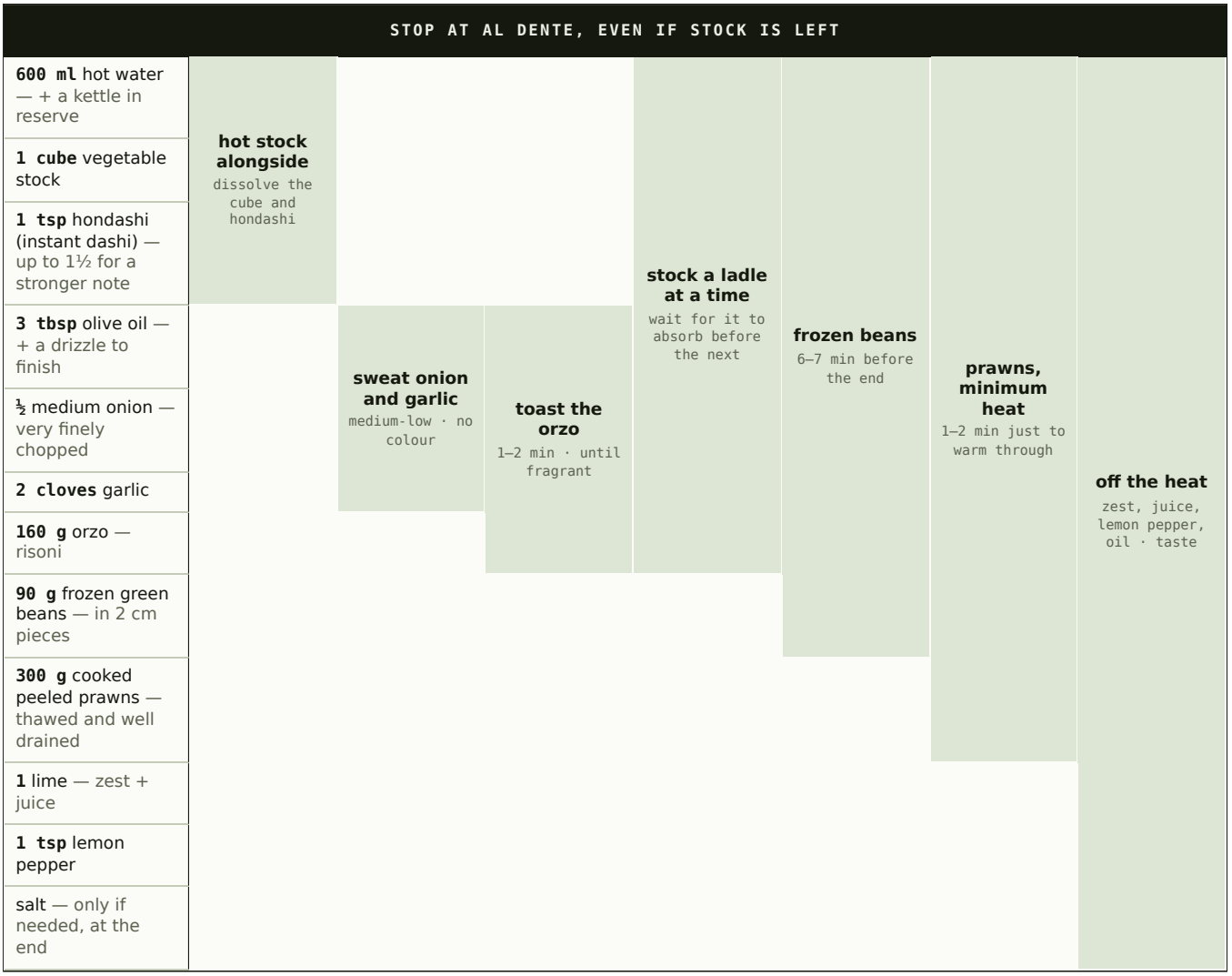
INGREDIENTS

- **600 ml** hot water — + a kettle in reserve
- **1 cube** vegetable stock
- **1 tsp** hondashi (instant dashi) — up to 1½ for a stronger note
- **3 tbsp** olive oil — + a drizzle to finish
- ½ medium onion — very finely chopped
- **2 cloves** garlic
- **160 g** orzo — risoni
- **90 g** frozen green beans — in 2 cm pieces
- **300 g** cooked peeled prawns — thawed and well drained
- **1** lime — zest + juice
- **1 tsp** lemon pepper
- salt — only if needed, at the end

METHOD

1. Heat the 600 ml of water with the stock cube and hondashi until dissolved. Keep it hot on low heat beside you, with a kettle of hot water in reserve.
2. Drain the prawns thoroughly and pat them dry. They come pre-cooked — they go in only at the end. Set aside.
3. Olive oil over medium-low heat, sweat the onion until translucent. Add the garlic and cook 1 minute without colouring — on this burner garlic burns in seconds.
4. Add the dry orzo and stir 1 to 2 minutes over medium heat, until fragrant and lightly coloured. It builds flavour and helps hold the bite.
5. Add the hot stock a ladle at a time, stirring and waiting for it to absorb before the next. Medium heat, a steady cheerful bubble.
6. About 6 to 7 minutes before the end, add the beans straight from the freezer.
7. Start tasting at 7 or 8 minutes. Orzo is fast — stop at al dente, even if stock is left. Doneness rules, not the clock.
8. Minimum heat or off. Add the prawns just to warm through, 1 to 2 minutes. Never longer.
9. Off the heat: zest and half the lime juice, lemon pepper, a drizzle of oil. Stir well so it stays creamy and loose (all'onda); add another ladle of stock if needed. Taste before you even think about salt.
10. Serve immediately — orzo keeps absorbing and thickens as it sits.

COOKING TABLE



NOTES

- 600 ml, not 700: what actually goes in is around 500 to 550 ml, the rest is slack. The mistake is dumping it all at once and drowning the pasta.
- A wide, shallow pan cooks in a thin layer and releases starch better. A deep pot piles the pasta up and it goes soggy underneath.
- Beef stock stays out of this: beef flavour fights the prawns.
- A small knob of cold butter whisked in at the end makes it silkier, if you like.

Syrian rice with chicken and za'atar

The flavour comes from the onion caramelized slowly; the chicken browned in batches keeps the fond that seasons the grains.

> High heat burns the onion instead of sweetening it, and that bitterness spreads through the whole pot — so it cooks slowly, without rushing. The chicken has to brown in batches: all at once it releases water, steams instead of searing, and loses the fond that seasons the grains. The lentils soak in boiling water so they reach the pot on the same clock as the rice — without that, the rice finishes while the lentils are still hard. And the za'atar only goes in where the heat is brief (searing the chicken, raw at the finish): 25 minutes of simmering softens the sesame, mutes the thyme and leaves the sumac's sourness diffused through the rice.

SERVES **6 servings** ACTIVE **30 min** TOTAL **70 min** VESSEL **Wide pot, 24 cm or more, thick bottom**

INGREDIENTS

- **1 cup** lentils — dry
- boiling water — to cover the lentils, about 2 finger-widths above
- **568 g** chicken breast — cut into ~1 × 7 cm strips
- **1 ½ tbsp** za'atar — for the chicken
- **1 tsp** Syrian pepper (baharat-style blend)
- **2 tsp** salt — plus pinches for the onion and the chicken
- **2** large onions — in half-moons · ~300 g each
- **¼ tsp** sugar
- **4 tbsp** olive oil — split between the onion and the chicken
- **3 cloves** garlic — finely chopped
- **1 ½ cups** white rice
- **½ tsp** za'atar — optional, in the grains
- **5 cups** water — for cooking
- **½ cup** chopped walnuts
- **2 tsp** za'atar — for the finish
- **1 tbsp** olive oil — for the finish
- **1 cup** plain yogurt

METHOD

1. Put the lentils in a deep bowl and cover with boiling water, about 2 finger-widths above. Leave them there while you do the rest.
2. Cut the chicken into ~1 × 7 cm strips. Season with the za'atar, half the Syrian pepper and a pinch of salt. Pat it dry first — a wet surface won't brown.
3. In the pot over medium heat, add half the olive oil and the onion, with a pinch of salt and the sugar. Lower the heat and cook for ~12 min, stirring occasionally, until well browned. Don't raise the heat to speed it up. Transfer to a bowl.
4. Turn up to medium-high, add the remaining oil and brown the chicken in 3 batches, without crowding the pot, stirring little so it colours. Set each batch aside with the onion as you go. The browned bits stuck to the pot are seasoning, not mess.
5. Return the chicken and onion to the pot, add the garlic and stir for 1 min. Add the rice, the remaining salt and Syrian pepper and, if using, the optional za'atar. Stir until every grain is coated.
6. Drain the lentils in a sieve and add them to the pot. Cover with the water, scrape the bottom and stir. Once it boils, lower the heat and leave with the lid ajar until the water dries up, ~25 min.
7. ⏳ Check at 20 min: if the water has dried up and the rice is still firm, add ½ cup of hot water and cover for another 5 min.

8. Turn off the heat and leave covered for 10 min. The grains finish cooking in the steam.
9. If the walnuts are raw, toast them for 3 min in a dry pan before chopping.
10. Mix the finishing za'atar with the oil and drizzle it over the yogurt. Serve the rice sprinkled with the walnuts and, if you like more za'atar, another raw pinch on top, with the yogurt on the side.

COOKING TABLE

CHICKEN IN BATCHES SO IT DOESN'T RELEASE WATER

- **1 cup** lentils — dry
- boiling water — to cover the lentils, about 2 finger-widths above
- **568 g** chicken breast — cut into ~1 × 7 cm strips
- **1 ½ tbsp** za'atar — for the chicken
- **1 tsp** Syrian pepper (baharat-style blend)
- **2 tsp** salt — plus pinches for the onion and the chicken
- **2** large onions — in half-moons · ~300 g each
- **¼ tsp** sugar
- **4 tbsp** olive oil — split between the onion and the chicken
- **3 cloves** garlic — finely chopped
- **1 ½ cups** white rice
- **½ tsp** za'atar — optional, in the grains
- **5 cups** water — for cooking
- **½ cup** chopped walnuts
- **2 tsp** za'atar — for the finish
- **1 tbsp** olive oil — for the finish
- **1 cup** plain yogurt

lentils soaking
boiling water, ~20 min, while you prep the rest

season the chicken
za'atar, half the Syrian pepper, a pinch of salt · pat dry first

onion caramelized slowly
low heat, a pinch of salt and sugar, ~12 min, no rushing

chicken in 3 batches
medium-high heat, don't crowd · set aside with the onion

season the grains
chicken and onion back in, garlic 1 min, rice, remaining salt and pepper

cooking with the drained lentils
lid ajar ~25 min · check at 20 · 10 min covered

toasted walnuts
3 min in a dry pan, if raw

yogurt with za'atar
za'atar mixed with the oil, drizzled on top

serve
rice topped with the walnuts, yogurt on the side

NOTES

- Adapted from Panelinha's "Syrian rice with chicken," which serves 2 with 240 g of chicken. Here the ratio was flipped to be more rice than lentils, scaled up to 568 g of chicken.
- A narrow pot piles the grains up: the bottom catches while the top is still raw. A thin bottom scorches the onion while it caramelizes.
- On a 4.5 kW burner, judge by what you see, not the dial: the onion should sizzle faintly, never fry; the chicken needs a strong sizzle — if it goes quiet, the pot is overcrowded.
- With more rice than the original, the chicken stretches thinner per serving. For a more protein-forward plate, serve 5 generous portions instead of 6.
- Za'atar heavy on the sumac? Cut the Syrian pepper in half so the two don't compete.
- The salt, cooking time and the pinch of za'atar in the grains are still being dialled in — next time will confirm whether the 25 min and 2 tsp of salt hit the right point.
- Leftovers reheat well with a splash of water, covered.

Mixed paella with arborio rice

Chicken, sausage and seafood with arborio instead of bomba rice — sofrito, saffron steeped in wine, all the stock at once, and no stirring.

> Arborio has more starch than bomba and absorbs less liquid: stirred, it turns creamy; left alone, it cooks into separate grains, just wetter than a true paella. That's why all the liquid goes in at once, in less volume than a risotto recipe would call for, in a wide pan that keeps the rice in a thin layer — and the heat diffuser on the 4.5 kW burner gives the even heat a paella pan gets for free.

SERVES **4 servings** ACTIVE **45 min** TOTAL **50 min** VESSEL **Wide skillet and heat diffuser**

INGREDIENTS

- **1 tbsp** olive oil
- **2** boneless, skinless chicken thighs — in small pieces
- **120 g** thin sausage — thin smoked sausage; fresh Italian sausage also works — see notes
- **1** small onion — finely chopped
- **2 cloves** garlic — chopped
- **1** roma tomato — grated without the skin, or finely chopped
- **2 tsp** smoked paprika
- **300 g** arborio rice — 1½ cups
- salt and black pepper
- **½ tsp** saffron threads
- **½ cup** dry white wine
- **3 ½ cups** chicken stock — hot, ~850 ml, + a kettle in reserve
- **400 g** seafood kit (squid, octopus, shrimp, mussels) — frozen — squid rings and pieces, octopus tentacles, pre-cooked peeled shrimp and mussels; thawed, drained and dried (~320 g). The seasoning sachet is optional — see notes
- **1 cup** frozen peas
- chopped parsley and lemon wedges — to serve

METHOD

1. Thaw the seafood kit in the fridge, or in cold water for 1 hour if you're short on time; drain and dry it well with paper towel. Split it into two piles: the squid, the only raw part, which needs 3 to 4 minutes of cooking, and the shrimp, mussels and octopus, which are already pre-cooked and only need warming through.
2. Heat the chicken stock and keep it hot on the lowest heat alongside — cold stock cools down the rice as it cooks.
3. Crumble the saffron threads into the white wine and let it steep while you prep everything else.
4. Oil over medium-high heat. Brown the chicken, stirring, until cooked, 5 to 8 minutes. Add the sausage and brown 2 to 4 more minutes. Remove both with a slotted spoon, leaving the fat in the pan.
5. Medium heat: onion and garlic in the fat, 1 to 2 minutes until soft. Add the tomato and cook until it dries out and the fat reappears. Paprika only in the last 30 seconds, to bloom without burning.
6. Add the rice and stir for 1 to 2 minutes until every grain is coated in fat and lightly translucent. Generous salt and pepper.
7. Add the saffron wine, scraping the bottom of the pan, and let it nearly evaporate.
8. Pour in all 3½ cups of stock at once, spread the rice into an even layer and don't stir anymore. Put the chicken and sausage back on top.
9. Medium-high heat for 8 minutes, bubbling hard; then low heat for another 10 minutes. If any spot dries out before the rice is done, a little stock from the kettle right there, without stirring.

10. At 14 minutes into cooking, scatter the squid and peas on top, pressing them in lightly. At 17 minutes, the shrimp, mussels and octopus, just to warm through — 1 to 2 minutes, never more, or they turn rubbery.

11. When the liquid disappears from the surface and the rice is al dente, high heat for 60 to 90 seconds for the socarrat — smell it: toasted is the point, burnt has gone too far.

12. Off the heat, cover with a clean kitchen towel, 5 minutes to rest. Serve straight from the pan, with parsley and lemon wedges on the side.

COOKING TABLE

ALL THE STOCK AT ONCE, THEN STOP STIRRING

- **1 tbsp** olive oil
- **2** boneless, skinless chicken thighs — in small pieces
- **120 g** thin sausage — thin smoked sausage; fresh Italian sausage also works — see notes
- **1** small onion — finely chopped
- **2 cloves** garlic — chopped
- **1** roma tomato — grated without the skin, or finely chopped
- **2 tsp** smoked paprika
- **300 g** arborio rice — 1½ cups
- salt and black pepper
- **½ tsp** saffron threads
- **½ cup** dry white wine
- **3 ½ cups** chicken stock — hot, ~850 ml, + a kettle in reserve
- **400 g** seafood kit (squid, octopus, shrimp, mussels) — frozen — squid rings and pieces, octopus tentacles, pre-cooked peeled shrimp and mussels; thawed, drained and dried (~320 g). The seasoning sachet is optional — see notes
- **1 cup** frozen peas
- chopped parsley and lemon wedges — to serve

saffron in the wine
steeping while you prep the rest

chicken and sausage
browned in the oil, set aside

sofrito and paprika
onion, garlic, tomato, paprika just to bloom

toast the rice
grain coated in fat, translucent · salt and pepper

deglaze with the wine
scraping the bottom, until almost dry

stock, all at once
chicken and sausage back in · no stirring, 8 min strong + 10 min low

seafood kit and peas
at 14 min the raw seafood, at 17 min the mussels

socarrat, rest and serve
high heat 60–90 s, 5 min covered · parsley and lemon

NOTES

- Adapted from a "risotto styled as paella" recipe (arborio, ladle by ladle, parmesan at the end) — the original is a risotto in disguise; this one swaps in the paella method and drops the cheese, which clashes with mussels and squid.
- The kit used was the 400 g Noronha Pescados one. Frozen, it comes to about 320 g once drained — with chicken and sausage in the dish, one kit is enough for 4 people; seafood alone, it would fall short, and the right call is 2 kits.
- Check the octopus as it thaws: it should give softly when pressed, a sign it's already cooked, like the rest of the kit. If it comes raw and firm, it won't work straight in this dish — it would need about 40 minutes of separate cooking first.
- The kit's seasoning sachet (8 g: garlic, onion, paprika, turmeric, bell pepper, parsley, nutmeg, cilantro and pepper) changes the profile — the turmeric yellows the rice over the saffron, and the cilantro throws off the flavor. Best to skip it; if used, at most half, cutting the paprika back to 1 teaspoon.
- The kit contains metabisulfite as a preservative; drying it well and discarding the thawing water helps get rid of the residual taste.
- Thin smoked sausage already brings smokiness and red fat; fresh Italian sausage brings fat and flavor but no paprika at all — hence the smoked paprika at 2 teaspoons. With smoked sausage, it can go back down to 1 teaspoon of sweet paprika.
- No cheese: parmesan on top of seafood doesn't work, and the creaminess it would bring is exactly what's not wanted here.
- Chicken is optional: without it, this becomes a seafood paella, and the stock can switch to fish or shrimp stock.

Cold farofa

The raw flours are hydrated by the oil, the lime and the water from the tomato. Nothing is cooked.

SERVES **6 servings** ACTIVE **25 min** TOTAL **55 min** VESSEL **Large bowl**

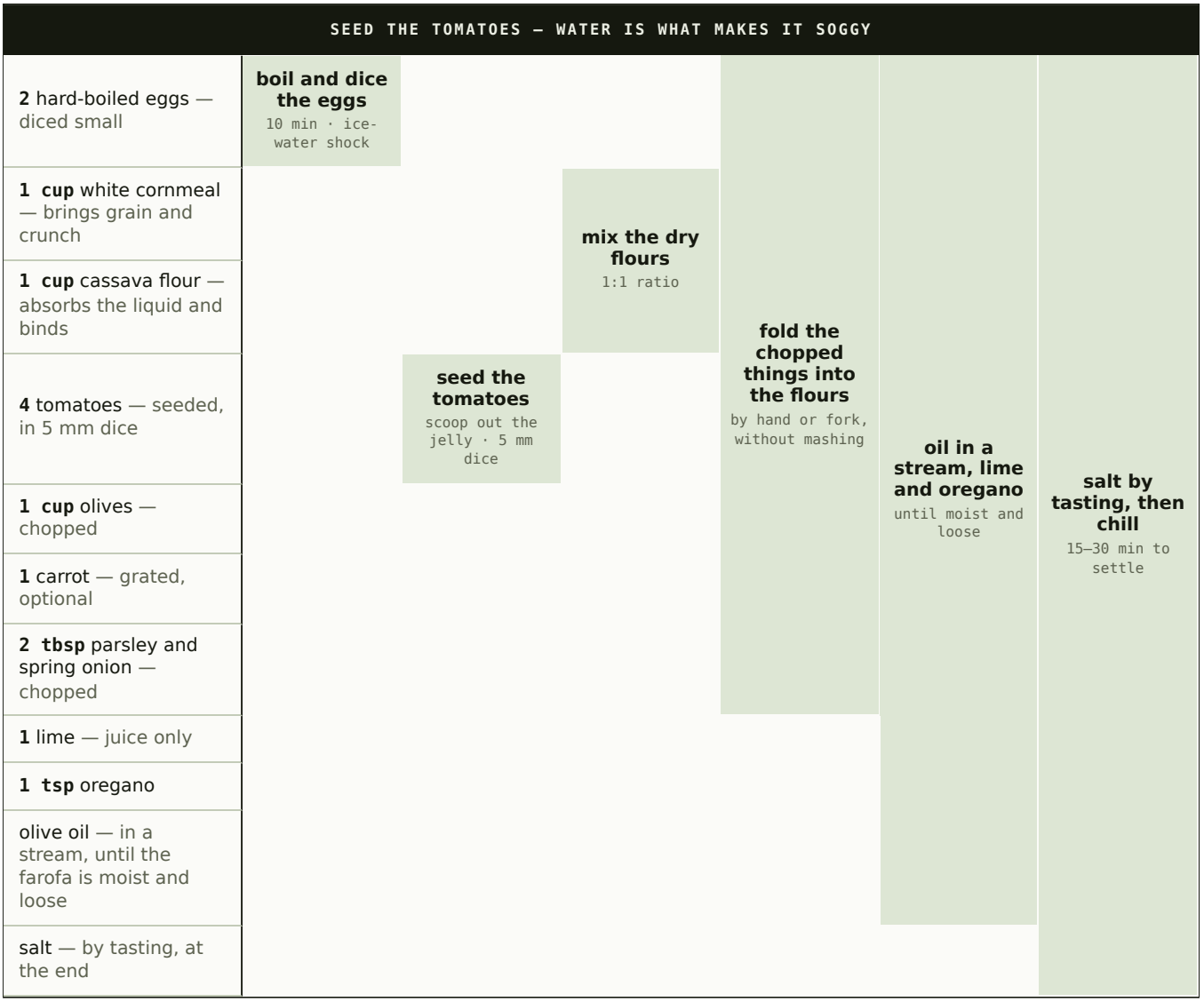
INGREDIENTS

- **2** hard-boiled eggs — diced small
- **1 cup** white cornmeal — brings grain and crunch
- **1 cup** cassava flour — absorbs the liquid and binds
- **4** tomatoes — seeded, in 5 mm dice
- **1 cup** olives — chopped
- **1** carrot — grated, optional
- **2 tbsp** parsley and spring onion — chopped
- **1** lime — juice only
- **1 tsp** oregano
- olive oil — in a stream, until the farofa is moist and loose
- salt — by tasting, at the end

METHOD

1. Boil the eggs for 10 minutes from the boil, shock them in ice water, peel and dice.
2. Halve the tomatoes, scoop out every seed and all the jelly with a spoon, and dice into about 5 mm. This is the step that decides whether the farofa stays loose or turns soggy.
3. Chop the olives and herbs, and grate the carrot if you are using it.
4. In a large bowl, mix the two flours while still dry.
5. Add the tomato, olives, egg, carrot and herbs. Mix with your hands or a fork, without mashing.
6. Oil in a thin stream, lime juice and oregano, mixing and checking the texture as you go. The point is moist and loose: squeeze a handful and it holds, then crumbles. Dry flour still in the bottom means more oil; glossy and heavy means you went too far.
7. Salt last, by tasting. The olives already brought sodium.
8. Chill for 15 to 30 minutes to settle. Serve the same day.

COOKING TABLE



NOTES

- Assemble close to serving: up to about 2 hours ahead is safe. Overnight the flour finishes absorbing everything and the farofa turns pasty — this is not a make-ahead recipe.
- Two flours at 1:1 is what the handwritten note says. More cornmeal makes it grainier; more cassava, denser and wetter at the right point.
- Lime near the end keeps the herbs bright; too early and the parsley wilts and darkens.
- No heat, but genuinely raw: well-cooked egg, washed tomatoes, and keep it refrigerated until serving — especially on a hot day.
- Variations on the same base: drained sweetcorn, red pepper in small dice, or a pinch of chilli flakes.

Molho alemão

A raw barbecue sauce: pepper, tomato, onion and garlic blended with oil, vinegar and tomato paste.

SERVES **~700 ml** ACTIVE **20 min** TOTAL **140 min** VESSEL **Blender and a clean glass jar**

INGREDIENTS

- **1** red bell pepper — or 4 — see the note
- **4** tomatoes
- **1** onion
- **4 cloves** garlic
- **200 ml** vinegar — 1 glass
- **200 ml** neutral oil — 1 glass · not olive oil
- **1** small tin of tomato paste
- salt — by tasting, at the end

METHOD

1. Pepper with no seeds and no white ribs. Tomato seeded, if you want a less watery, less bitter sauce. Onion and garlic peeled, in large pieces — the blender will handle it.
2. Blend the pepper, tomato, onion and garlic with the vinegar — the acid liquid helps the machine pull everything down. Blend to a smooth purée.
3. With the motor running, add the oil in a thin stream. Dumping it in at once will split it. The sauce lightens and thickens slightly as it takes.
4. Add the tomato paste, blending to incorporate. If you prefer to calibrate, add it by the spoonful until you reach the colour and body you want — it should run off the spoon, not stand up on it.
5. Salt, by tasting. The tomato paste already brings sodium.
6. Adjust the acidity: if it is aggressive, a pinch of sugar or a little more paste rounds it off; if it is flat, another splash of vinegar.
7. Clean glass jar, refrigerated, at least 2 hours before serving. It improves a lot by the next day, when the raw garlic loses its edge.

COOKING TABLE

OIL IN A THIN STREAM WITH THE MOTOR RUNNING — OR IT SPLITS					
1 red bell pepper — or 4 — see the note	**clean and roughly chop** pepper deribbed · tomato seeded	**blend with the vinegar** to a smooth purée	**oil in a stream, motor running** the sauce lightens and thickens	**tomato paste** colour and body · it should run off the spoon	**salt and acidity, by tasting** clean jar · at least 2 h in the fridge
4 tomatoes					
1 onion					
4 cloves garlic					
200 ml vinegar — 1 glass					
200 ml neutral oil — 1 glass · not olive oil					
1 small tin of tomato paste					
salt — by tasting, at the end					

NOTES

- The note says "1 red pepper or 4". With 1, the sauce is sharper and thinner; with 4, it is fuller, sweeter and much redder, with less vinegar showing — and it probably needs less paste.
- Raw garlic is the ingredient that changes most with time: on the day it is sharp and aggressive, by the next day it is round. Always worth making it the day before.
- Keeping: covered glass jar in the fridge, and preferably eaten within 4 to 5 days — it is raw garlic blended with oil, with no measured acidity or pH, so it is not a candidate for long storage. Separation is normal, shake before serving. Always serve with a clean spoon, and never return what was left on a plate.
- Non-reactive container: glass or ceramic, never aluminium — vinegar reacts and leaves a metallic taste. Same rule as the escabeche.
- Neutral oil, not olive oil. Olive oil turns heavy and bitter in a high-speed blender; here the fat's only job is to carry the flavour of the vegetables.
- Chopped version: the same ingredients in 5 mm dice, unblended, make a pepper vinaigrette. That is a different sauce — the blender is what makes it the "alemão".

Tuna spread, two consistencies

The sandwich's firm filling and the bowl's loose dip start as the same mixture and split apart at the end.

> The sandwich spread needs to be firm so it doesn't run into the bread; the bowl dip needs to be looser so it doesn't crack the chip when scooped. The only difference between the two is the last step: more mayonnaise, more lime and herbs in the portion that goes into the bowl — because that version is seen up close and eaten on its own, while the sandwich version stays hidden.

SERVES **~600 g for the bowl + 250–350 g for sandwiches** ACTIVE **15 min** TOTAL **15 min**

VESSEL **Sieve and bowl**

INGREDIENTS

- **4** cans of solid tuna in oil — very well drained, ~480 g drained
- **300 g** cream cheese or thick spreadable cheese
- **100 g** mayonnaise — +1 tbsp for the bowl version
- **80 g** thinly sliced red onion
- **1** lime — juice, + a splash at the end for the bowl version
- black pepper
- salt — only after tasting
- **2 tbsp** chopped parsley and spring onion — bowl version only

METHOD

1. Drain the tuna in a sieve, pressing with the back of the spoon — far more liquid comes out than you'd expect, and that liquid is what would loosen the spread later.
2. Slice the red onion very thin (the processor's slicing disc, not the S-blade), leave it in ice water for 5 minutes and drain well — it takes off the raw bite.
3. Mix the tuna, cream cheese, 100 g of mayonnaise, the onion, lime juice and pepper. Taste before you think about salt — canned tuna and cream cheese already bring sodium.
4. Set aside the sandwich portion, 250 to 350 g depending on the recipe, in a container — that one stays as is, firm.
5. In the rest, the bowl version: one more spoonful of mayonnaise, a splash of lime and the herbs. Mix until it falls slowly off the spoon.
6. Plastic wrap pressed onto the surface of both containers, no air bubble, and into the fridge.

COOKING TABLE

TASTE BEFORE YOU THINK ABOUT SALT — TUNA AND CREAM CHEESE ALREADY BRING SODIUM

- **4** cans of solid tuna in oil — very well drained, ~480 g drained
- **300 g** cream cheese or thick spreadable cheese
- **100 g** mayonnaise — +1 tbsp for the bowl version
- **80 g** thinly sliced red onion
- **1** lime — juice, + a splash at the end for the bowl version
- black pepper
- salt — only after tasting
- **2 tbsp** chopped parsley and spring onion — bowl version only

1. **drain the tuna** — in the sieve, pressing with the spoon
2. **onion in ice water** — 5 min · takes off the raw bite
3. **mix the base** — tuna, cream cheese, mayonnaise, onion, lime, pepper · salt only after tasting
4. **set aside the sandwich portion** — 250–350 g · stays firm
5. **loosen the bowl portion** — the rest of the base +mayonnaise, +lime, herbs

NOTES

- A chip dip is defined by viscosity, not flavor: the right point is falling slowly off the spoon, without running.
- Air is the enemy, not time: plastic wrap pressed flat against the surface, with no air bubble, solves drying-out as much as shelf life.
- Stored with the wrap pressed on, the bowl version keeps in the fridge until the next day without trouble — but the sandwich portion is best kept under 2 days, because of the mayonnaise and the egg in commercial cream cheese.
- A barbecue sauce doesn't become a chip dip: tried and dropped. Molho alemão, for instance, is thin on purpose, to cut through fatty meat — thickening it enough would make it a different sauce.

Guacamole

Fork-mashed, kept chunky — the one thing on the menu that genuinely benefits from being made at the last minute.

SERVES **~600 g** ACTIVE **5 min** TOTAL **5 min** VESSEL **Fork and bowl**

INGREDIENTS

- **600 g** avocado flesh — 1 large avocado, or 3 hass avocados
- **1 ½** lime — juice only
- **30 g** thinly sliced red onion — sliced the night before, along with the onion for the spread
- **6 g** salt — 1% of the flesh's weight
- black pepper
- cilantro — only if everyone likes it

METHOD

1. Mash the avocado with a fork, keeping it chunky — three pulses in a food processor turns it to purée, and that's a different thing.
2. Add the lime, onion, salt and pepper. The lime isn't just for flavor: the acid slows the enzyme that causes browning.
3. Smooth the surface with the back of the spoon, plastic wrap pressed on with no air bubble, lid on top.
4. Take it in the bowl you'll serve it from, so it only gets opened once.

COOKING TABLE

LIME, ONION AND BUBBLE-FREE WRAP — NOT TIMING — CONTROL BROWNING			
600 g avocado flesh — 1 large avocado, or 3 hass avocados	**mash with a fork** kept chunky, no food processor	**season** lime, onion, salt, pepper	**smooth and store** bubble-free wrap, in the serving bowl
1 ½ lime — juice only			
30 g thinly sliced red onion — sliced the night before, along with the onion for the spread			
6 g salt — 1% of the flesh's weight			
black pepper			
cilantro — only if everyone likes it			

NOTES

- Made the morning you leave, not the night before — it's the one thing on the menu that genuinely benefits from last-minute prep, and it costs five minutes.
- The avocado needs to already be ripe on the day you buy it, giving slightly near the stem — a hard avocado won't ripen in time for tomorrow's picnic.
- Made ahead works, made fresh is better: with lime and the wrap pressed on it survives the night fine, the browning is only surface-deep — but if the alternative costs five morning minutes, spend them.
- Tomato stays out: it releases water and thins the dip — same rule as the cold farofa.
- If there's a dark line on top at serving time, it's half a millimeter of surface oxidation — scrape it off with the spoon and stir before serving.

Sardine escabeche

Fried fast, then cured in a warm bath of vinegar, oil and aromatics.

SERVES **4 servings** ACTIVE **40 min** TOTAL **4h40** VESSEL **Glass or ceramic dish**

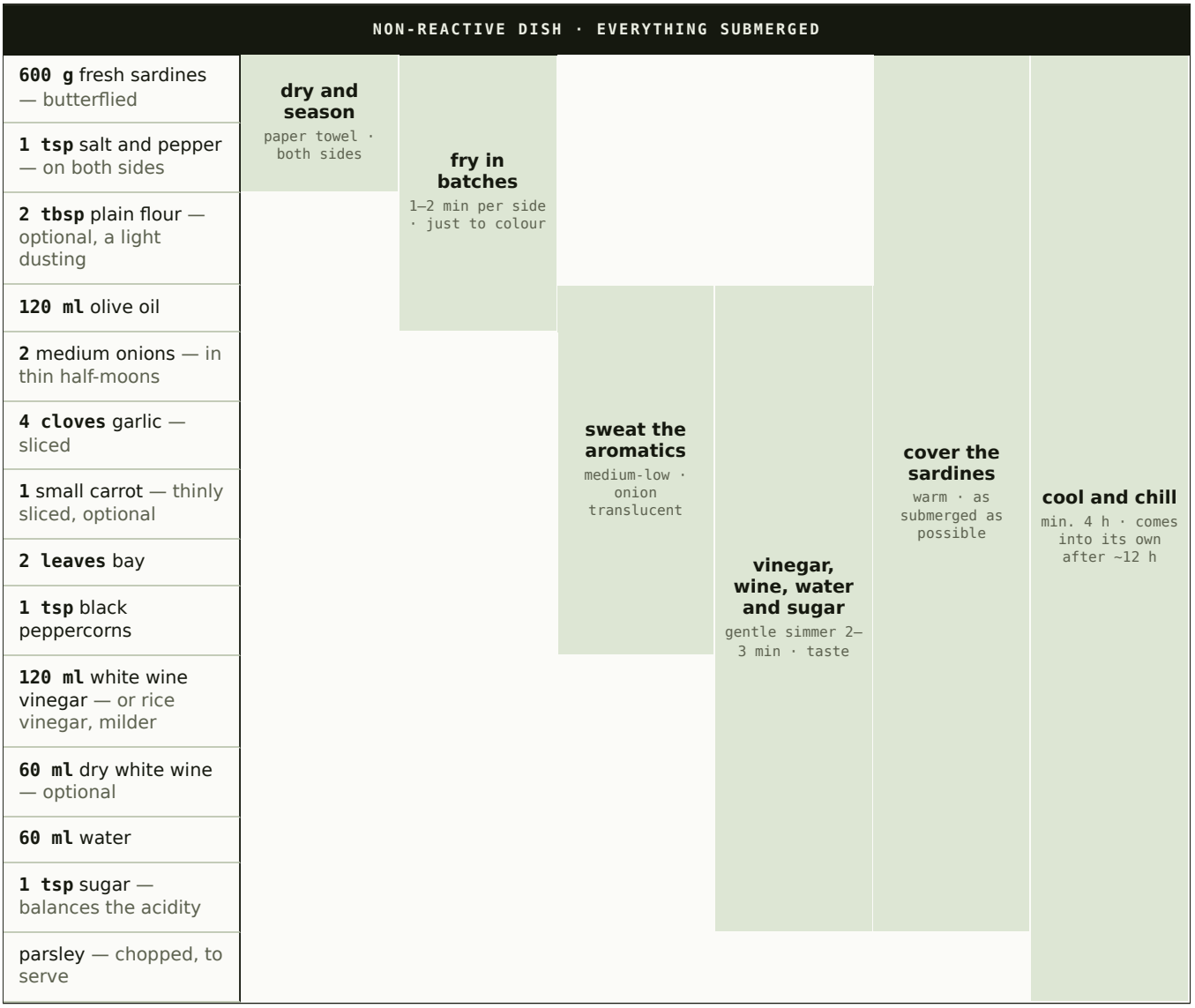
INGREDIENTS

- **600 g** fresh sardines — butterflied
- **1 tsp** salt and pepper — on both sides
- **2 tbsp** plain flour — optional, a light dusting
- **120 ml** olive oil
- **2** medium onions — in thin half-moons
- **4 cloves** garlic — sliced
- **1** small carrot — thinly sliced, optional
- **2 leaves** bay
- **1 tsp** black peppercorns
- **120 ml** white wine vinegar — or rice vinegar, milder
- **60 ml** dry white wine — optional
- **60 ml** water
- **1 tsp** sugar — balances the acidity
- parsley — chopped, to serve

METHOD

1. Dry the sardines well with paper towel and season with salt and pepper on both sides.
2. If you like, dust them lightly with flour and shake off the excess. Fry in very hot oil, in batches without crowding, 1 to 2 minutes per side, just until lightly golden. Transfer to a glass or ceramic dish.
3. In the same oil, over medium-low heat, sweat the onion, carrot, garlic, bay and peppercorns until the onion is soft and translucent — without much colour.
4. Add the vinegar, wine, water and sugar. Simmer gently for 2 to 3 minutes, just to take the raw bite off the vinegar. Taste and balance acidity and salt.
5. Pour the warm escabeche over the sardines, leaving them as covered as possible by the liquid and the onion.
6. Let it cool 20 to 30 minutes on the counter — not hours — then cover and refrigerate. Rest at least 4 hours; it comes into its own after about 12.

COOKING TABLE



NOTES

- Eaten cold or at room temperature, never reheated, with bread. Keeps 4 to 5 days in the fridge and improves the next day.
- As a gift: frying late afternoon and delivering the next morning gives 14 to 16 hours of curing, the best window.
- Olive oil, not lard: lard sets solid and turns white in the fridge.
- Never aluminium or iron — vinegar reacts with metal and leaves a metallic taste.
- The fine bones soften in the acid in about a day and become edible.
- With rice vinegar, milder and sweeter, you can leave out the sugar.

Lacto-fermented hot sauce

Brazilian Tabasco style: fruity base, malagueta as the only heat. Makes 450–550 ml.

SERVES **450–550 ml** ACTIVE **40 min** TOTAL **7 days** VESSEL **Clean glass jar or bottle**

INGREDIENTS

- **346 g** dedo-de-moça chilli (fresh cayenne-like) — fresh, trimmed
- **40 g** malagueta (piri-piri) chilli — the volume knob — calibrate by tasting
- **5 cloves** garlic
- **380 ml** filtered water — enough to submerge
- **23 g** salt — 3% of chilli + water weight
- **45 ml** rice or cider vinegar — only at the end, to taste

METHOD

1. Remove the stems and chop coarsely by knife, into rounds. No blender at this stage — a purée is a different method, without water. Keep the seeds for medium heat. Wear a glove with the malagueta, wash your hands well and do not rub your eyes.
2. Layer into a scrupulously clean jar or bottle: dedo-de-moça, garlic and the starting amount of malagueta.
3. Taste the raw blend and adjust the heat with more malagueta if you want. You can go up, not down — and fermenting does not remove heat, it only rounds it.
4. Cover with water until submerged. Weigh the whole thing — chilli plus water — and add 3% salt. Dissolve it well.
5. Keep everything submerged: a clean bag filled with 3% brine (not plain water) pushed into the neck acts as a weight and seals off the air. No chilli above the liquid line — that is where mould starts.
6. Loose lid: fermentation releases CO_2 and a full bottle overflows in the first days. Room temperature, out of the sun, on a saucer to catch spills. It will cloud and bubble — that is right.
7. Ferment from one week to a few months. Start tasting from day five to seven; the endpoint is taste.
8. To finish: drain, reserving the brine, blend the chillies and garlic with a little of it, adjust with vinegar, bottle in clean glass and keep refrigerated.

COOKING TABLE

SALT AT 3% OF CHILLI + WATER WEIGHT · EVERYTHING SUBMERGED							
346 g dedo-de-moça chilli (fresh cayenne-like) — fresh, trimmed	**chop coarsely, by knife** no stems · seeds in · wear a glove	**taste the raw blend** adjust heat with more malagueta	**cover with water** in the clean jar	**weigh and salt at 3%** of the chilli + water weight	**submerge, loose lid** room temperature, out of the sun, on a saucer	**ferment** 1 week to a few months · taste from day 5	**blend and bottle** adjust with vinegar · refrigerate
40 g malagueta (piri-piri) chilli — the volume knob — calibrate by tasting							
5 cloves garlic							
380 ml filtered water — enough to submerge							
23 g salt — 3% of chilli + water weight							
45 ml rice or cider vinegar — only at the end, to taste							

NOTES

- To scale: malagueta at ~10% of the dedo-de-moça weight gives medium heat; salt always 3% of chilli + water weight.
- Kahm (a smooth white film) is a harmless yeast, spoon it off. Mould — anything fuzzy, any colour — means discarding the whole batch.
- Pimenta de cheiro is not a substitute for biquinho: it is in the habanero family and can be brutally hot. For aroma without fire, use biquinho.
- A narrow-necked bottle is the most awkward shape for keeping everything submerged.

No-knead sandwich bread

The gluten develops on its own, through hydration and time — four quick folds do the work a stand mixer would.

> Kneading is just a sped-up way of aligning gluten chains. Hydrated, resting dough does the same work alone, only slower — and the folds, spaced out over time, organise the network with no effort. The one rule that never reverses: butter and egg get in the way of gluten formation, so they go in after the flour has already hydrated.

SERVES **1 loaf, 22–24 cm pan** ACTIVE **15 min** TOTAL **8 h**

VESSEL **22–24 cm loaf pan, ideally lidded (pullman-style)**

INGREDIENTS

- **250 g** warm whole milk — finger-warm, not hot
- **30 g** sugar
- **4 g** instant dried yeast — ~1 level teaspoon
- **1** egg
- **400 g** wheat flour — ideally strong bread flour, higher in protein
- **8 g** salt
- **40 g** unsalted butter — well softened
- extra butter — for greasing the pan and brushing at the end

METHOD

1. In a large bowl, mix the warm milk, sugar and yeast. Add the egg. Add the flour and salt and mix with a spatula only until no dry flour remains — it will look messy and sticky, and that is correct. Cover and rest.
2. Add the softened butter and work it in by hand, pinching and folding the dough over itself inside the bowl. It will look like it has fallen apart, then come back together. Do not knead.
3. Fold 1 of 4. Wet your hand, pull one edge of the dough up and fold it over the centre, turn the bowl 90° and repeat 4 times — it takes 30 seconds. Cover and rest.
4. Fold 2 of 4. Same motion. The dough is already visibly smoother. Cover and rest.
5. Fold 3 of 4. Same motion — the gluten network is taking shape. Cover and rest.
6. Fold 4 of 4, the last one. The dough should be elastic and smooth by the end of this round.
7. Bulk fermentation: let it rest covered until nearly doubled — 1 to 2 h, depending on the kitchen's temperature.
8. Turn the dough out onto a lightly floured counter, degas it with your hands and divide into 3 equal balls. Roll each one out into a rectangle and roll it up tight like a Swiss roll. Place the 3 rolls side by side in the greased pan, seam down.
9. Cover and let it rise until the dough reaches about 1 cm from the rim of the pan (or fills about 80% of the height, if lidded). Test: press gently with a finger — the mark should spring back slowly, not vanish completely.

10. Preheat the oven to 180 °C. Bake for 30 to 35 minutes — if the pan is lidded, 30 min covered and 5 min uncovered, to brown. Doneness is 90 to 93 °C at the centre; a thermometer is the only reliable way to know.

11. Brush butter on the still-hot crust, unmould it right away and cool it on a rack. Wait for it to cool completely, at least 2 hours, before slicing — hot bread is still cooking inside, and cutting it early leaves the crumb gummy.

COOKING TABLE

OVEN DONENESS: 90–93 °C AT THE CENTRE — ONLY A THERMOMETER CONFIRMS IT								
250 g warm whole milk — finger-warm, not hot	**mix** until no dry flour remains · rest 30 min	**work in the butter** by hand, in the bowl · do not knead	**four folds** one every 30 min · 30 s each	**bulk fermentation** until nearly doubled · 1–2 h	**shape** 3 rolls in the greased pan, seam down	**final proof** to ~1 cm from the rim · 1–1.5 h	**oven 180 °C** 30–35 min · 90–93 °C at the centre	
30 g sugar								
4 g instant dried yeast — ~1 level teaspoon								
1 egg								
400 g wheat flour — ideally strong bread flour, higher in protein								
8 g salt								
40 g unsalted butter — well softened								
extra butter — for greasing the pan and brushing at the end								**brush and cool** unmould right away · cool 2 h before slicing

NOTES

- Kitchen temperature governs everything: the times above hold at around 24 °C. Below that (18–20 °C), add 30 to 50% to each stage. Never go by the clock alone — go by volume and the finger test.
- Plain flour works, but gives a lower, more crumbly loaf; higher-protein flour performs better. With only plain flour on hand, a tablespoon of vital wheat gluten fixes it.
- Salt and yeast together, dry and direct, is not a problem at these quantities — the myth that salt "kills" yeast only holds for prolonged, concentrated contact.
- Slicing and freezing is what makes this sustainable: fully cooled bread, sliced, in a freezer bag, goes straight from frozen into the toaster. It keeps a month. On the counter, 2 to 3 days in a plastic bag — never in the fridge, which speeds up staling.
- Cold-fermentation version, more practical for a weekday routine: cut the yeast to 2 g, do the mix/butter/folds as normal, and refrigerate the covered bowl for 12 to 16 h right after the last fold. The next day, shape it while still cold (it handles more easily) and do the final proof at room temperature — it takes longer, 2 to 3 h, since the dough needs to warm up before rising. Bonus: more flavour.
- Tangzhong upgrade, for the cost of 1 extra minute: set aside 20 g of the flour and 100 g of the milk from the recipe, cook the two together over low heat, stirring constantly, until it turns into a thick paste (about 1 min), let it cool to warm and add it in the first step with everything else. It makes the bread noticeably softer and extends its shelf life to 4 or 5 days.

Caprese ciabatta with arugula

Cherry tomato, buffalo mozzarella and basil on toasted ciabatta — a recipe about managing water, not about assembly.

> Cherry tomatoes and buffalo mozzarella are the two wettest things in the fridge, and ciabatta's open crumb is the worst place to put either. The method is a sequence of barriers: tomato drained in a sieve before it goes in, bread toasted in oil to seal the surface, and arugula as a cushion between the crumb and the filling.

SERVES **2 sandwiches** ACTIVE **15 min** TOTAL **15 min** VESSEL **Skillet or griddle**

INGREDIENTS

- **2** ciabatta rolls — or 1 large one, cut in half
- **4 tbsp** olive oil
- **250 g** cherry tomatoes
- **1 tbsp** balsamic vinegar
- **½ tsp** salt
- **200 g** buffalo mozzarella
- **60 g** arugula
- fresh basil — generously, whole leaves
- black pepper — freshly ground

METHOD

1. Halve the cherry tomatoes, season with the salt and balsamic and leave them in a sieve over a bowl for 10 minutes — the salt draws out the water, the balsamic seasons them, and the excess leaves with the liquid.
2. Tear the mozzarella by hand into large pieces and spread them on paper towel — tearing gives more surface to hold the oil than a clean slice would.
3. Split the ciabattas open, brush half the oil on the cut faces and toast crumb-side down in a skillet or on a griddle until golden, 2 to 3 minutes.
4. Layer from the bottom up: arugula, drained tomato, mozzarella, whole basil leaves — chopped, it oxidizes and darkens in minutes.
5. Finish with the remaining oil, black pepper and salt only if it needs it. Close it up, press lightly with your palm and cut on the diagonal.

COOKING TABLE

BALSAMIC ON THE TOMATO, NEVER ON THE ASSEMBLED SANDWICH					
2 ciabatta rolls — or 1 large one, cut in half			**toasted bread** half the oil, crumb side down, 2–3 min		
4 tbsp olive oil					
250 g cherry tomatoes	**tomato in the sieve** salt + balsamic, 10 min draining				
1 tbsp balsamic vinegar				**assembly** arugula → tomato → mozzarella → basil	**finish and cut** rest of the oil, pepper, diagonal cut
½ tsp salt					
200 g buffalo mozzarella		**mozzarella drying** torn by hand, on paper towel			
60 g arugula					
fresh basil — generously, whole leaves					
black pepper — freshly ground					

NOTES

- Balsamic goes on the tomato, in the sieve — never drizzled over the assembled sandwich, where it soaks the crumb and runs down your hand.
- Buffalo mozzarella never sees heat: it melts into watery strings and loses what makes it good. If the craving is for an orzo with the same ingredients, it goes in raw and torn, off the heat, softening only in residual warmth.
- Ciabatta is the right bread for its crust: it holds the crumb together as the filling compresses. A soft-crumbed loaf falls apart when pressed.
- Arugula is barrier and counterpoint: its bitterness balances the tomato's sweetness and the mozzarella's milk fat, which together turn a bit flat.
- It's the opposite of the picnic sandwich in this chapter: there is no version of this one that survives overnight. To travel, the components go separately and assembly happens on arrival.

Picnic tea sandwiches

Twenty crustless sandwiches, wrapped individually, built to survive a night in the fridge and a morning in a cool box without going soggy.

> The bakery-counter version turns soggy for one reason: it puts everything inside. This one is defined by two decisions — cream cheese to the edge on both slices, as a fat barrier against the filling's water, and a list of what stays out: tomato, never; lettuce only on the side; carrot always on the coarse grater, which releases a third of the water the fine one does.

SERVES **20 whole sandwiches / 40 halves — 6 adults and 6 kids** ACTIVE **35 min** TOTAL **12h35**

VESSEL **Counter space and an airtight container**

INGREDIENTS

- **40** slices of crustless sandwich bread — 2 loaves
- **350 g** cream cheese or thick spreadable cheese — the firm tub kind; the runny cup kind will leak
- black pepper
- oregano
- lime zest — zest of ½ lime
- **350 g** firm tuna spread — see the recipe for it
- **300 g** sliced white cheese or mozzarella — 24 slices
- **250 g** coarsely grated carrot — 2 medium carrots, well dried

METHOD

1. Set up the counter with two rows of 20 slices — the top row is the lid, the bottom is the base — with a butter knife, serrated knife, plastic wrap and a rigid container close at hand.
2. Season the cream cheese in a bowl with the pepper, oregano and lime zest. If it's still cold and stiff, beat it smooth first — too cold, it tears the bread.
3. Spread the seasoned cream cheese on all 40 slices in one pass, a thin layer edge to edge.
4. Fill the 20 bases, starting with the tuna ones: a heaping tablespoon, leaving a 1 cm border free — it spreads on its own as you close it. On the cheese ones, 2 slices with the carrot on top of the cheese, never touching the bread.
5. Close it up and press lightly with your palm, just until the filling touches both faces and seals the edges.
6. Cut on the diagonal with a serrated knife, one motion only — sawing back and forth pushes the filling out. Wipe the blade every 4 or 5 cuts.
7. Wrap each half tightly in plastic wrap, in the position it ended up — the wrap is what holds its shape and keeps the compression.
8. Slot the sandwiches upright, side by side like a filing cabinet, into a rigid container. Fridge, on the middle shelf, until morning.

COOKING TABLE

CREAM CHEESE TO THE EDGE — IT'S THE BARRIER, NOT JUST FILLING					
40 slices of crustless sandwich bread — 2 loaves					
350 g cream cheese or thick spreadable cheese — the firm tub kind; the runny cup kind will leak	**season the cream cheese** pepper, oregano, lime zest	**cream cheese on all 40 slices** thin layer, edge to edge	**fill the 20 bases** tuna, or cheese + carrot	**close, cut, wrap** diagonal, one motion	**container and fridge** standing up, until morning
black pepper					
oregano					
lime zest — zest of ½ lime					
350 g firm tuna spread — see the recipe for it					
300 g sliced white cheese or mozzarella — 24 slices					
250 g coarsely grated carrot — 2 medium carrots, well dried					

NOTES

- Damp carrot is the sandwich's only source of water: grate it, spread it on paper towel and let it dry while you do everything else. If it's still wet at assembly time, give it five more minutes.
- Do each motion forty times in a row, not twenty whole sandwiches one at a time — it changes the timing completely: about 35 minutes this way, nearly double the other way.
- Without turkey, the cheese doubles: 2 slices per sandwich, not 1 — without the cold cut, cheese becomes the protein. With turkey, it goes back to 1 slice and 2 slices of sliced turkey breast go in.
- Lettuce, if it's used, goes in whole and very dry in a separate container, and gets tucked in on the spot — once the sandwiches are individually wrapped, nobody's going to unwrap one just to add a leaf.
- 20 for 12 people sounds like a lot and isn't: a cut sandwich is the item people come back for. If it's the only savory thing on the menu, consider making 24.
- The tuna spread is the same one from the bowl-dip recipe, in the firm version set aside before loosening the bowl version — see that recipe.

Purée #4 — peas, beetroot and ground beef

It comes out purple and sweet — usually the favourite.

> The beef is what carries the iron in this dish — the beetroot is there for colour, sweetness and variety, not as a meaningful iron source. It takes over the colour and sweetens it considerably. It stains the nappy too: that is normal.

SERVES **8–12 frozen portions (~1.2–1.5 kg)** ACTIVE **30 min** TOTAL **50 min** VESSEL **Pressure cooker**

INGREDIENTS

- sunflower oil — for the sofrito, plus a drizzle to serve
- **1** onion
- **4 cloves** garlic
- **200 g** ground beef
- **200 g** beetroot — in 2 cm cubes
- **200 g** potato — in 2 cm cubes
- water — not quite covering
- **230 g** peas
- **200 g** spinach
- herbs and spices — no salt

METHOD

1. Peel and chop everything. Beetroot and potato in 2 cm cubes.
2. Oil in the open cooker, onion until soft, garlic just until fragrant.
3. Ground beef, breaking it up with the spoon until no pink remains.
4. Beetroot, potato and water not quite covering. Lid on, 5 to 6 minutes from the hiss.
5. Open the cooker. Peas and spinach in the residual heat, lid off.
6. Herbs and spices off the heat. Mash to the texture of the stage.
7. Portion, cool fast and freeze the same day.

COOKING TABLE

NO SALT · THE GREENS GO IN AFTER THE PRESSURE				
sunflower oil — for the sofrito, plus a drizzle to serve	**sofrito** onion → garlic → beef, until no pink remains	**pressure** 5–6 min from the hiss · beetroot is hard	**lid off** peas and spinach, 2 min	**season and mash** texture to suit the stage
1 onion				
4 cloves garlic				
200 g ground beef				
200 g beetroot — in 2 cm cubes				
200 g potato — in 2 cm cubes				
water — not quite covering				
230 g peas				
200 g spinach				
herbs and spices — no salt				

NOTES

- Frozen peas go in after opening the cooker; dried peas cook from the start with the vegetables.

Purée #5 — beans, arracacha and lime

Cinnamon with lime zest is the prettiest seasoning in the whole set of notes.

> The only meatless one: the iron comes from the beans, which is absorbed less readily, so this one wants citrus fruit for dessert right after. Arracacha gives a silkier texture than potato — worth saving for when you want a softer purée.

SERVES **8–12 frozen portions (~1.2–1.5 kg)** ACTIVE **30 min** TOTAL **70 min** VESSEL **Pressure cooker**

INGREDIENTS

- **200 g** beans — soaked 8–12 h, water changed
- sunflower oil
- ½ onion
- **4 cloves** garlic
- **200 g** arracacha (Andean root) — in 2 cm cubes
- **200 g** carrot — in 2 cm cubes
- water — not quite covering
- **100 g** spinach
- cumin
- cinnamon
- lime zest

METHOD

1. Soak the beans overnight, changing the water once.
2. Pressure-cook the beans alone until they crush between your fingers. Set aside with some of their liquid.
3. Oil, onion until soft, garlic just until fragrant.
4. Arracacha and carrot in cubes, the beans with some liquid, water not quite covering. Pressure.
5. Open and add the spinach in the residual heat.
6. Cumin and cinnamon in the last minutes; zest off the heat. Mash.
7. Portion, cool fast and freeze the same day.

COOKING TABLE

NO SALT · BEANS COOKED SEPARATELY, UNTIL THEY COLLAPSE					
200 g beans — soaked 8–12 h, water changed	**soak and pressure, separately** 8–12 h soak · 20–25 min pressure				
sunflower oil		**sofrito** onion until soft, garlic just until fragrant			
½ onion			**pressure** 4–5 min · with the beans and some of their liquid		
4 cloves garlic				**lid off** spinach, 2 min	
200 g arracacha (Andean root) — in 2 cm cubes					**season and mash** zest off the heat
200 g carrot — in 2 cm cubes					
water — not quite covering					
100 g spinach					
cumin					
cinnamon					
lime zest					

NOTES

- The zest is there for aroma, not vitamin C — what actually helps iron absorption is citrus fruit right after the meal.

Purée #6 — chickpeas, squash and beef

The most nutritionally complete: animal and plant protein in one dish.

> Squash brings vitamin A and thickens by itself. Cinnamon and squash is a classic pairing and works beautifully with no sugar at all. Go easy on the water — squash and chickpeas release plenty, so start with less.

SERVES **8–12 frozen portions (~1.2–1.5 kg)** ACTIVE **30 min** TOTAL **75 min** VESSEL **Pressure cooker**

INGREDIENTS

- chickpeas — soaked 12 h
- sunflower oil
- onion
- garlic
- ground beef
- squash — in 2 cm cubes
- potato — in 2 cm cubes
- water — less than usual
- spinach
- cinnamon
- cumin

METHOD

1. Soak the chickpeas 12 h; pressure-cook them alone until they truly collapse — undercooked, the skins leave little pellets.
2. Oil, onion, garlic, then the beef until no pink remains.
3. Squash and potato in cubes, the chickpeas, water sparingly. Pressure.
4. Open and add the spinach in the residual heat.
5. Cinnamon and cumin. Mash to the texture of the stage.
6. Portion, cool fast and freeze the same day.

COOKING TABLE

NO SALT · LESS WATER THAN USUAL					
chickpeas — soaked 12 h	**soak and pressure, separately** 12 h soak · 25 min pressure				
sunflower oil		**sofrito** onion, garlic, beef until no pink remains	**pressure** 4 min · squash cooks fast	**lid off** spinach, 2 min	**season and mash**
onion					
garlic					
ground beef					
squash — in 2 cm cubes					
potato — in 2 cm cubes					
water — less than usual					
spinach					
cinnamon					
cumin					

NOTES

- The original note listed only ingredients, no amounts — and none were invented. The proportions of the other purées (200 g per item, 100 g of greens, 200 g of protein) fit well if you want to repeat it.

Purée #7 — pork and leek

Leek is sweeter and gentler than onion — good for a baby who balks at strong flavours.

> A lean pork cut — leg or loin — shreds well under pressure and turns tender without going pasty. A fattier cut tastes better but means skimming afterwards. This was the leek's only appearance in the series and it deserved a comeback.

SERVES **8–12 frozen portions (~1.2–1.5 kg)** ACTIVE **30 min** TOTAL **50 min** VESSEL **Pressure cooker**

INGREDIENTS

- sunflower oil
- onion
- leek — white and pale green, thinly sliced
- pork — leg or loin, in small cubes
- potato — in 2 cm cubes
- carrot — in 2 cm cubes
- water — not quite covering
- spinach
- spices — no salt

METHOD

1. Oil, onion and thinly sliced leek, softened without colouring.
2. Pork in small cubes, seared until no pink remains.
3. Potato and carrot in cubes, water not quite covering. Pressure.
4. Open and add the spinach in the residual heat.
5. Spices off the heat. Mash to the texture of the stage.
6. Portion, cool fast and freeze the same day.

COOKING TABLE

NO SALT · ONLY THE WHITE AND PALE GREEN OF THE LEEK				
sunflower oil	**sofrito and sear** onion and leek, then the pork	**pressure** 5 min from the hiss	**lid off** spinach, 2 min	**season and mash**
onion				
leek — white and pale green, thinly sliced				
pork — leg or loin, in small cubes				
potato — in 2 cm cubes				
carrot — in 2 cm cubes				
water — not quite covering				
spinach				
spices — no salt				

NOTES

- No measurements in the original note — nothing was invented. If you repeat it, the proportions of the others (200 g per item, 100 g of greens, 200 g of protein) are a starting point.

Purée #8 — chicken, beans and carrot

The most neutral of the series, good for a day when the baby is resisting.

> Chicken with beans gives enough protein with a mild flavour. 100 g of animal protein to about 700 g of vegetables is the lightest ratio of the five — it works because the beans fill the gap.

SERVES **8–12 frozen portions (~1.2–1.5 kg)** ACTIVE **30 min** TOTAL **70 min** VESSEL **Pressure cooker**

INGREDIENTS

- **200 g** beans — soaked 8–12 h
- sunflower oil
- **1** onion
- **5 cloves** garlic
- **100 g** chicken — in small cubes
- **200 g** carrot — in 2 cm cubes
- **200 g** potato — in 2 cm cubes
- water — not quite covering
- **100 g** spinach
- cumin
- cinnamon

METHOD

1. Soak the beans overnight; pressure-cook them alone until they collapse.
2. Oil, onion until soft, garlic just until fragrant — five cloves is a lot, and that's fine.
3. Chicken in small cubes until no pink remains.
4. Carrot and potato in cubes, water not quite covering. Pressure.
5. Open, add the beans and spinach in the residual heat.
6. Cumin and cinnamon. Mash to the texture of the stage.
7. Portion, cool fast and freeze the same day.

COOKING TABLE

NO SALT · FIVE CLOVES OF GARLIC IS A LOT, AND THAT'S FINE					
200 g beans — soaked 8–12 h	**soak and pressure, separately** 20–25 min pressure				
sunflower oil		**sofrito** onion, garlic, chicken until no pink remains	**pressure** 5 min from the hiss	**lid off** beans and spinach, 2 min	**season and mash**
1 onion					
5 cloves garlic					
100 g chicken — in small cubes					
200 g carrot — in 2 cm cubes					
200 g potato — in 2 cm cubes					
water — not quite covering					
100 g spinach					
cumin					
cinnamon					

NOTES

- Swap the chicken for 50 g of finely chopped liver, cooked with the onion, and this becomes the highest-iron purée in the book.

Quentão with honey

Honey does not caramelise: it burns fast and turns acrid. The cost of the swap is only colour.

SERVES **6 servings** ACTIVE **10 min** TOTAL **30 min** VESSEL **Saucepan**

INGREDIENTS

- **750 ml** water
- **80 g** fresh ginger — sliced
- **3 sticks** cinnamon
- **8** cloves
- **1** orange peel
- **500 ml** cachaça
- **120 g** honey — starting point — adjust by tasting

METHOD

1. Pan with the water, ginger, cinnamon, cloves and orange peel. Bring to a boil, lower and simmer about 15 minutes, to draw out the flavour of the spices and ginger.
2. Add the cachaça and keep it on low heat, without a hard boil, to marry the flavours. Five minutes keeps the alcohol; fifteen or more makes it much gentler.
3. Turn it off — or leave it on the lowest setting — and stir in the honey until dissolved. Do not boil after this, or you lose the aroma. Taste and adjust the sweetness: honey is more assertive than sugar.
4. Strain and serve very hot, in mugs.

COOKING TABLE

DO NOT CARAMELISE THE HONEY				
750 ml water	**infuse the aromatics** boil, then 15 min on low	**cachaça, low heat** 5 min keeps the strength · 15+ softens it	**turn off and dissolve the honey** no boiling after this	**strain and serve** very hot, in mugs
80 g fresh ginger — sliced				
3 sticks cinnamon				
8 cloves				
1 orange peel				
500 ml cachaça				
120 g honey — starting point — adjust by tasting				

NOTES

- Honey is sweeter than sugar: start with 120 g and adjust at the end, never the other way round.
- Want the toasted background that caramel would give? Push the cloves and cinnamon.
- Chopped apple alongside the orange makes it fruitier.

ABOUT

About this notebook

This is not a cookbook in the usual sense. It is the notebook where I write down what worked in my kitchen, with the reasons why — why the pan starts cold, why salt goes in last, why fried rice needs yesterday's rice. The recipes were cooked, eaten and corrected before they became text.

Each recipe appears in several formats, because the same recipe serves different purposes. The classic view is for reading beforehand. The cooking table — an idea borrowed from Cooking for Engineers — shows the whole recipe at once, and is the best way to see what happens in parallel. The flowchart draws the same path: what goes into each step and what joins what. The interactive view rescales servings and units. And kitchen mode is for dirty hands: one step at a time, with timers on the timed stages.

The quantities are the ones I use, not ones a professional test kitchen validated. Where the original recipe had no measurement, I did not invent one. Where timing depends on your stove, the text tells you what to look for instead of giving a number.

If something here helps you, good. If something is wrong, tell me.

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